

**UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

**COURSE: ALL COURSES**

**LECTURER: EUNICE WAITIKI**

**Objectives: At the end of the lesson, the students should:**

- ❖ **Learn the definition of communication**
- ❖ **Understand the purpose of communication**
- ❖ **Understand the importance of communication**
- ❖ **Familiarize themselves with objectives of communication**
- ❖ **Learn the element of communication process**

**Definition of communication.**

1. Communication is an act of any natural or artificial means of conveying information or giving instruction.
2. It's the process of passing information and understanding from one person to the other.
3. **According to Newman and summer** communication is an exchange of facts, ideas, opinions or emotions by two or more persons.

4. **According to Peter Little** communication is process by which information is transmitted between individuals/organization so that understanding response results.

It's giving, receiving or exchange of information, opinions, or ideas by writing speech or visual means or any combination of the three so that the material communicated is completely understood by everyone concerned.

**5. Administrative communication –**

Administrative communication is a process involving the transmission and accurate replication of ideas ensured by feedback for purpose of eliciting actions which will accomplish organizational goals.

## *(Analysis)*

This definition has emphasized the following points:-

- It involves the communication of ideas.
- Ideas should be accurately replicated. The receiver should get exactly the same ideas as were transmitted.
- Transmitter is assured of accurate replication of ideas by feedback.
- Purpose of communication is to elicit action.

This definition can be expanded to include emotions.

The purpose of communication is not always to elicit action it may also include communication to seek information or to persuade other person to a certain point of view.

## **PURPOSE OF COMMUNICATION**

### **Why do we communicate?**

-Effective communication is achieved when we speak, write or express ourselves through body actions; visual symbols achieve the intended purpose. When we write, speak, persuade, inform, entertain, explain, convince or educate, we strive to achieve one or more of the following objectives:

- ✓ To be heard and to be understood
- ✓ To read and comprehend
- ✓ To be acceptable
- ✓ To have action taken

-As noted above, we always have an objective when communicating. Effective communication will also enable you to:

- Get the job you want

- Boost your chances for promotion
- Help others get things done
- Benefit your business
- Improve your grades,
- Advance socially
- Ensure a bright future
- Enhance other skills
- Helping others get ahead

## **Main aspect (components) of communication**

- Communication must have a source (sender)
- Communication must have content (message)
- Communication must have a media
- Communication must have a destination: i.e. recipient
- Communication must have a feedback.

## **Importance of communication**

- Communication can be described as the life blood of the business
- No business can develop in the absence of effective external and internal communication.
- Communication is a vital tool of management.

-One of the major functions of an office is communication. This involves receiving, recording, processing of information and communicating the information two various functions of the organizations.

Importance of communication can be discussed under two points of view.

I. Internal communication

II. External communication.

## **A) Importance of internal communication**

Internal communication refers to exchange of information or message between persons of same organization, e.g. between employer and employee.

### **i) Better understanding between employer and employees.**

- If complaints of employees are forwarded to employer on time and in the right way it will minimize the chances of misunderstanding.

### **ii Greater efficiency.**

The sound communication system enables the management to instruct the supervisions and subordinates on changes of policy - this results to the increase in efficiency of workers.

### **iii) Effective co-ordination:**

Effective communication leads to effective co-ordination of employees' e.g if demand increase the marketing department will inform the production department to increase its production.

### **iv) Proper communication avoids losses:**

If there is a machine breakdown or shortage the management can be informed quickly to take timely action to avoid any possible losses.

## **B) External communication.**

This refers to exchange of information between an organization and other organizations or persons outside the organization.

The following facts indicate the importance of external communication:

## **Good reputation**

Effective communication with customers and either business enables company establish good reputation this increases prestige of that company.

## **ii) Improvement in public relations:**

When a company communicates with general public to keep them informed of its activities more people become interested to deal with that company.

## **iii) Better business prospects –**

Due to good communication the company can abstract more customers.

## **iv) Choice of customers –**

A company can get information about the liking and disliking of customers. This information will help company produce goods according to the choice of customers.

## **v) Government department –**

The business will deal with licensing authorities, foreign trade offices, custom authorities, banks and other financial institutions. All these institutions require good communication when negotiating.

## **vi) Job requirements –**

Most jobs require communication skills such as personnel public relations, marketing, editing, research, advocates, etc.

Executives are expected to make speeches they are expected to give interviews to media. All these require communication skill.

## **1.2. OBJECTIVES OF COMMUNICATION**

### **i) To inform –**

One of most important objectives of communication is passing and receiving information about of particular fact of circumstance.

An organization can inform consumers about its products, availability of credit, availability of raw materials, or about government rules and regulations.

It can also communicate to inform staff about the latest development in the field of science and technology.

Within the organization you can inform employees about job assignments, or inform them of general information on policies and activities of organization.

## **ii) To advice**

Information is factual and objective, advice on the other hand involve personal opinions. It is subjective and neutral.

When advice is given to person he /she may use it or decide not to use it. An advice is aimed at influencing the opinion or behavior of another person.

Advice flows downwards or horizontally, e.g. from a doctor to patient and not vice versa.

## **iii) To order**

An order is an authoritative communication; it is a directive to somebody (subordinate) to do something to modify or not to do something.

Orders flow from top to bottom.

## **iv) To suggest (make suggestion)**

A suggestion is different from other forms of communication. In other forms it flows from superiors to subordinates but, a Suggestion may flow from subordinate to superior. A suggestion is mild or subtle and it moves in all directions.

## **v) To persuade**

This is communication aimed at influencing the attitudes, feelings or beliefs of others.

## **vi) To Educate**

Education is a conscious process of communication. It involves teaching and learning, its main purpose is to widen knowledge and improve skills.

## **vii) To warn someone**

If employees don't abide by the rules of the organization they will be warned.

## **viii) Raise the morale.**

Morale-stands for mental health.

It's a powerful factor representing the sum of many qualities such as courage, fortitude, resolution and confidence.

## **ix) TO motivate**

Motivation is very close to raising of morale. It means to energize and activate a person and challenge his or her behavior towards the attainment of desired goals.

## **1.3. ELEMENTS OF COMMUNICATION**

### **iv) The sender**

This is the person responsible for sending the communication it can be an individual or a group such as a company, a department, a government ministry etc.

**V) The message:** after defining the information to be conveyed, the sender puts this into the best form in a process called encoding. When information has been encoded it is referred to as a message. A message takes the form of a letter, a memo, telephone call, or a shrug of shoulders.

### **vi) The media**

This is a larger group of ways of communication within which particular ways of communication can be classified. There are three main media.

- Written communication e.g. letters, memo, books, posters
- Oral communication: this is communication using word of mouth e.g meetings, lectures, telephones or discussions.
- Visual communication: it takes the form of photographs, blackboards etc.

In addition to these three media we also have non-verbal communication that is combination of gestures, expressions, tone of voice, position, posture, etc.

## **vii) The channel:**

This the physical means by which message is conveyed for written communication channel may be notice board, postal office.

For oral communication. It may be personal interview, committee meeting, or public telephone call.

For visual communication the channel may be computer printer, fax system or printing press.

## **viii) The receiver:**

Is the person or body which receives the message.

It can be an individual or an organization.

## **ix) The noise:**

Noise is used to refer to any factors which prevent proper exchange of information apart from that from the sender or receiver. Noise can be physical e.g. typewriters or the telephone bells which interrupt meetings, or it can be some other form of interference such as bad telephone connections, poor handwriting in letter, conflicting messages, e.g. in oral communication the visual expression conveys a difference message from that being given orally.

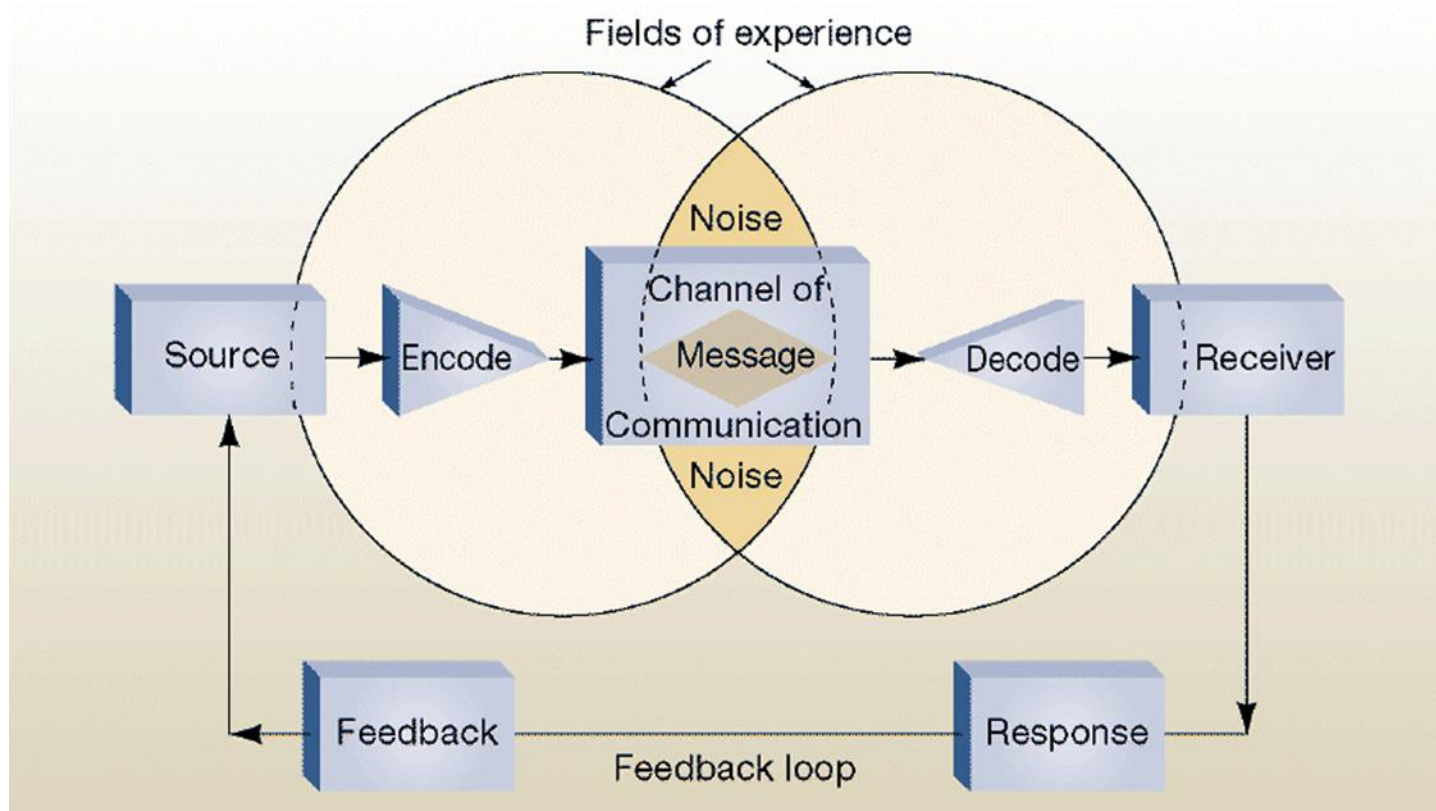
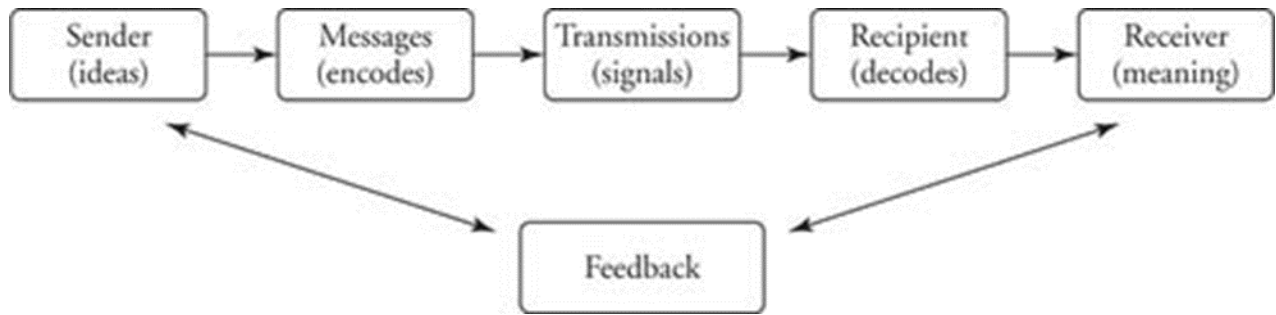
## **xi) Feedback:**

This is the name given to the message which the sender receives from the receiver to show the acceptance or disapproval of message, such a smile.

## **1.4. COMMUNICATION CYCLE**

**QUESTION: Draw the communication cycle.**

**Discuss the importance of communication skills in everyday life**



**UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

**COURSE: ALL COURSES**

**LECTURER: EUNICE WAITIKI**

**LESSON 2: COMMUNICATION PROCESS**

**INTRODUCTION**

My name is Madam Eunice Waitiki, holder of B.A (Communication and Media) lecturer at ICS college Nakuru campus school of media studies .I am glad to be

with you today and thank you for making time to join me today in this lesson. I express my sincere gratitude.

By the end of this lesson, I hope you will be able to tackle any exam questions or class assignments given to you. I hope that you will be able to apply the content learnt here to real life situations.

The unit is very simple and it's my hope that you will go through it again and again for easier understanding. Some of the exam questions comes from this topic and if you study well you will highly pass your exams and become a motivation to other students.

## **UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

### **COURSE: ALL COURSES**

### **LESSON 2: COMMUNICATION PROCESS**

**OBJECTIVES;** At the end of the lesson, the students should:

- ❖ Understand the process of communication

### **PROCESS OF COMMUNICATION**

Communication is a process that involves two parties – the sender and the receiver. This means that communication is a two-way process. It, basically involves the sender and the receiver.

### ***STAGES IN THE COMMUNICATION PROCESS***

#### **STAGE 1: CONCEIVING THE MESSAGE**

The first stage in the communication process is the decision made by a sender to communicate a message, such as a scream of fright or gasp of pain. Others are the result of an impulse which occurs so quickly that the sender is barely conscious of having decided to say or do anything.

+The sender has the need to communicate a message. this could be as a result of (a) impulse, (b) thought process (c) external stimulus/reflex action (where sender is barely conscious of it e.g. shout.

## STAGE 2: ENCODING THE MESSAGE

Before the message is sent to the recipient, the sender needs to encode it in an appropriate language. The language may take the form of an abrupt gesture of impatience or a carefully written letter or report. It may also take the form of a picture, symbol or non-verbal expression or gesture. The languages of communication include the following:

- The spoken word (oral)
- The written word
- The number
- The picture, drawing or symbol or
- The non-verbal communication – expression, gesture
- Posture

The eventual success of the message depends on the choice of an appropriate language.

+when the sender is ready with the message, then it is ready for transmission (sending the message). Therefore, it is up to the sender to make sure that the message accurately reflects what is intended and is then presented in the most suitable format. – Clarity of purpose, message and delivery are essential elements of effective communication.

## STAGE 3: SELECTING THE COMMUNICAITON CHANNEL

A channel is a *vehicle* by which the message is passed on to the audience. For you to select/choose an appropriate channel, ask yourself: Am I going to communicate by use of words, pictures or both? Which medium would be the most appreciated by the audience – written or spoken, a letter or personal chat?

Once the language has been chosen, the sender needs to select a medium through which to transmit the message. The choice of medium depends upon a number of, sometimes quite complicated factors. If the message is disciplinary, then a formal, private interview may be required.

Some messages must be written – contracts are an obvious example – and geographical distance may require that the message is transmitted in letter-form. Sometimes the very complexity of a message dictates that it is produced as a written report which may be composed and studied in stages. Alternatively, the need for a quick exchange of attitudes and opinions may suggest a meeting as the best medium.

+once the sender has encoded and is ready to send the message, he/she has to choose the appropriate medium/channel to do this: this could be the following: face-to-face – meetings, interviews, presentations, informal discussions etc.; oral – using telephone, cell phone, voice mail, answering machines etc.; written- using letters, memos, reports, forms, fax messages, text messages or e-mail etc.; visual- using charts, tables, diagrams, slides, maps or notices etc.

The likely effect of a message upon its receiver will also influence the choice of medium. Bad news, for example, is much better broken in a private interview than more impersonally in a letter. Factors influencing the choice of the communication medium are:

- Potential effectiveness
- Need for fact
- Simultaneous reception of information by recipients
- Need for a written record
- Confidentiality
- Need for instant feedback
- Complexity of the message
- Time
- Cost

What is a medium? It is a way/means of expressing your ideas/of communicating with people. Substance or materials e.g. Blood is the medium in which oxygen is carried to all parts of the body. Media= plural for medium. Television, newspapers, magazines internet etc are examples of medium/media

## STAGE 4: DECODING THE MESSAGE

Before a message can be absorbed or acted upon, it first needs to be understood. Many messages are ineffective because the sender failed to realize that the language he had chosen was beyond the ability of his receiver to comprehend. Terms like 'burn it' and 'jargon' are frequently employed when someone has used inappropriate language. Some of the reasons for failure by a receiver to decode a message successfully are:

+ Interpreting the Message: the receiver ensures that he/she understands the underlying as well as the explicit meaning e.g. a received message may conceal a hidden meaning – message to be read 'between the lines'. The receiver must interpret the message correctly as intended by the sender.

1. The receiver does not share the sender's language
2. The sender's jargon (words or phrases) is unknown to the receiver. When we used words, we should always remember the following:
  - Words mean different things to different people
  - Words mean different things to the same person at different times
  - The word is not the thing – it is merely a symbol to represent the thing

- We can never communicate to another person exactly that we think and feel
- 3. The sender is a specialist and the receiver is layman
- 4. Education, cultural pursuits and outlooks create a language block between sender and receiver.
- 5. Ensure that your chosen language is fully comprehensible to the receiver. Put yourself in his or her position. Try to ascertain your receiver's abilities and limitations.
- 6. Take care that your message is not capable of being misinterpreted. Avoid vagueness or ambiguity.
- 7. Check that you are receiving the desired feedback – answers, confirmations, indications or attitudes.

## AS A RECEIVER:

1. Give the incoming message all your attention. Avoid being side-tracked or distracted
2. Check that the sender's chosen communication medium is meeting your needs. Help the sender to put his message across effectively by letting him know tactfully if the medium is inappropriate.
3. Ensure that you comprehend the message fully. Seek confirming feedback from the sender if the message is not clear by asking for explanations or repeats.
4. Take care to interpret the message correctly. Check whether there is any underlying or implied meaning in the message.
5. Avoid the temptation deliberately to *misinterpret* a message as a means of retaliating against its sender. If you are not on good terms, endeavor to thrash the matter out of goodwill.
6. Provide the sender with sufficient feedback. Reassure him that you have received and understood the message.

## 5 FEEDBACK

It is important that the receiver sends feedback to the sender. The receiver, therefore, however how busy, must take immediate steps to provide feedback. This could be in the form of signals passed to the sender – e.g. written reply, spoken word or person to person communication. By sending back the feedback, the process starts again

There are quite a number of problems that may occur at different stages during the process and it is important to know this. They include:

- Message ill-conceived/vague/ambiguous

- Message encoded in wrong language, inappropriate tone
- Use of wrong medium, time wasting, expensive, no written record
- Receiver unable to comprehend sender's language, use of jargon/vocabulary unfamiliar to receiver
- Message wrongly interpreted, poor relationship between receiver and sender
- Feedback not given or interpreted wrongly

Noise or interference (barriers) in different stages can affect the delivery of the message. This can interfere with the encoding and decoding stages. Any kind of interruption that distracts or distorts the message from being understood correctly or clearly is considered as noise. E.g. dressing, religious affiliations, aroma or even stench.

## SUMMARY

In summary we note that communication is a two way process that takes place through several stages which include: conception, decoding, comprehension, interpretation and feedback.

Hence:

1. Conception of the message happens when an idea, thought or feeling is formulated in the mind of the sender as a result of an external or internal stimulus or due to motivation. At this stage, the sender decides on the nature of the message.
2. encoding of the message involves giving the message a communication form. This may be verbal or non-verbal.
3. Channel – the sender selects the most appropriate and effective vehicle that will deliver the message to the receiver. The media may include telephone, fax, letter, mouth etc.

\*It is only after careful selection of the most appropriate medium/channel that effective communication will be achieved. The following are factors to consider when selecting/choosing the most appropriate channel to use:

**(a) Cost (time & money): the channel selected should be cost-effective in terms of time and money.**

**(b) Speed: the urgency of the message is important. The channel selected should be appropriate to deliver the message within the expected time.**

**(c) Audience: The medium selected should be one that can serve the communication needs of the target audience, in terms of age, education background among others.**

**(d) Availability the medium selected should be available both to the sender and receiver. A television may not be the most appropriate medium to send a message to people living in places where electric power is not available.**

(e) **Message:** *the message will dictate the type of channel to be used in a particular situation, the complexity, urgency, the purpose of the message.*

(f) **Confidentiality** *Different messages require different levels of confidentiality especially in today's world where technology has made great strides.*

4. **Transmission:** the message is transferred to the receiver through the selected channel. At this stage, there is possibility of the message being interfered with by “noise”

5. **Reception:** this is the physical act of receiving the message through any of the six senses – the sense of hearing, touch, taste, sight and smell.

6. **Decoding:** this involves the receiver trying to assign meaning to the language used. This is done by relating the language to the knowledge of terms and vocabulary. Comprehension takes place when the receiver tries to spend moments to absorb the meaning and understand the technical jargon used by the sender.

7. **Interpretation** is similar to what is loosely termed as ‘reading between the lines’. This means that you as the receiver should search for the underlying meaning.

8. **Feedback:** this involves reacting to the message received. The message is encoded and a response is given in a language that the sender can understand. The communication process is then complete when the message is transmitted back to the originator of the message (that is the sender). The receiver goes through the same communication process as the sender had done. Only when this cycle is completed, can communication be said to have been effective.

**Assignment: Please draw the communication cycle**

**UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

**COURSE: ALL COURSES**

**LESSON 3: PRINCIPLES/QUALITIES OF COMMUNICATION**

**Objectives: At the end of the lesson, the student should:**

❖ **Understand the different qualities of communication**

**1.5. QUALITIES OF COMMUNICATION**

**THE SIX C's OF COMMUNICATION**

## 1. CLARITY

This is divided into

- (a) Clarity of thought
- (b) Clarity of expression

### **(a) Clarity of thought.**

- This is important when the idea is being generated in the mind of the sender
- At this stage, three points should be checked upon

i) What is the objective of the communication?

Example: - to warn, educate, congratulate

ii) What is to be communicated?

Example: - A song, play, poem etc.

iii) Which medium is appropriate for the purpose of communication?

Example: - Letters, photographic, interviews. Etc. Sender Information Receiver

### **(b) Clarity of Expression**

The following tips should be considered

#### **i. Avoid jargon**

Jargon is a special language of trade, certain profession or field of study e.g. medicine, business and only understood and used by people from such fields. It therefore creates a scenario of difficult understanding to those who are not from that field.

Example: in law, the phrase “Jurisdiction of the court of appeal”. This could only be understood by those in the field of law a doctor may not understand such a term.

#### **ii. Avoid ambiguity**

An ambiguous message is one that contains words that have more than one meanings. This may encourage misinterpretation of the words.

Example: - The word dispense could mean both

(i) to prepare medicine

(ii) To dismiss someone

### **iii. Use short sentences**

Short sentences are easier to comprehend for they are not complex and do not demand greater concentration as is the case for long ones.

### **iv. Use of simple words**

Simple words tend to be more effective for they are easily understood and are interpreted correctly.

Example: Use of the word before instead of, prior to

### **v. Use of concrete expression**

Concrete expressions create visual images that are easy to register and remember.

This can be achieved by avoiding being too general or vague in your expressions.

Example: you can say, 'that dress is expensive for it costs shs.150, 000/' 'instead of plainly saying 'that dress is expensive'.

## **2. CONCISENESS**

- It is important for your message to be straight to the point by not loading the message with irrelevant and unnecessary details.

- Be as brief as possible but not at the expense of clarity, correctness or courtesy.

- If a reader feels that he/she is wasting his/her time on your message e.g. letter, he may opt to disregard it.

### **How to achieve conciseness**

i) Avoid repetition

Example: Me, i am thanking you.....”

ii. Include only relevant facts and details

iii. Organize your message well i.e. the introduction, the body of the message and the conclusion.

- iv. The message should be coherent, i.e. it should hold together.
- v. Avoid wordy expressions, figures of speech and ambiguous words.

### 3. CONSIDERATION

In your message, you should always show consideration for the reader or listener. This can be done in the following ways.

#### (a) **Impact integrity to your message**

- Ethical principles of sincerity and fair treatment should be observed.

#### (b) **Emphasize positive and pleasant statement**

- In case where one has to send a message of regret, use positive and pleasant words.

Example of negative expression – “We are sorry to inform you that you have not been admitted to this school”

Positive expression – “**Thank you** for your application for a course in

Micro- finance; you are however advised that the commencement date is July next year....

#### (c) **Adopt the “You” attitude**

- Avoid ‘I’ and ‘we’ in you message. The “you” attitude is highly recommend for it shows greater respect and consideration for the recipient.

Example of ‘I’ attitude: “I am happy that you considered my application”

Example of ‘You’ attitude: “Thank you for your quick response to my letter”

### 4. COURTESY

This calls for a considerate and friendly attitude towards the other the receiver. The following points may assist in promoting courtesy:

- (a) Answer the letters promptly or respond to the message promptly
- (b) Omit negative expressions such as “we regret” instead use friendly statements such as “we shall see to it that...”

(c) Apologize sincerely for an omission and thank generously for any favour done.

Example of an apology: – We sincerely apologize for not dispatching your goods on time”.

## 5. COMPLETENESS

- Complete presentation of facts and details is necessary in any business communication

- Incomplete communication leads to ineffectiveness of the action to be taken, irrelevancy, misinterpretation and misunderstanding of the message. This is because it leaves a number of questions unanswered.

- Example: When replying to an enquiry from a customer wishing to buy a car, one must include all relevant facts about the car such as the model, colour, price mode of payment and other specifications.

- The message should be well organized in such a way that the reader/listener is not in doubt about the details contained in it.

- **Tips for communication completeness**

- (a) While answering a letter, include all relevant details and answer all questions if any.

- (b) Check on the “5w’s questions to why? What? Where? Who? When?

## 6. CORRECTINESS

This simply means:

- a) Giving correct facts/statements/arguments etc.
- b) Sending the message at the correct time
- c) Send the message in the correct style/medium/channel.

**QUESTION: Explain how an individual can achieve conciseness in his/her writing**

**UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

**COURSE: ALL COURSES**

**LESSON 4: BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION PROCESS**

**Objectives: At the end of the lesson, the student should:**

- ❖ Understand what a barrier is
  - ❖ Learn the different barriers in the communication process
  - ❖ Understand how to overcome the barriers in communication process
- 
- Barriers: These are the factors that cause problems for communication – they hinder the clear interpretation and reception of message. In some situations, they are known as **blockers**
  - We must be aware of them if we are to overcome them or communicate in such a way as to minimize their effect.
  - There are many reasons why interpersonal communications may fail. In many communications, the message (what is said) may not be received exactly the way the sender intended. It is, therefore, important that the communicator seeks feedback to check that their message is clearly understood.
  - There are many barriers to communication and these may occur at any stage in the communication process. Barriers may lead to your message becoming distorted and you therefore risk wasting both time and/or money by causing confusion and misunderstanding. Effective communication involves overcoming these barriers and conveying a clear and concise message.

**Categorization of Barriers to Communication**

- 1) **Language Barriers** when communicating in the same language, the terminology used in a message may act as a barrier if it is not fully understood by the receiver(s). For example, a message that includes a lot of specialist jargon and abbreviations will not be understood by a receiver who is not familiar. Clearly, language and linguistic ability may act as a barrier to communication. However, even with the terminology used, regional colloquialisms and expressions may be misinterpreted or even considered offensive.
- 2) **Psychological Barriers** The psychological state of the receiver will influence how the message is received. For example, if someone has personal worries and is stressed, they may be preoccupied by personal concerns and not as receptive to the message as if they were not stressed. Stress management is an important personal skill that affects our interpersonal relationships.

Anger is another example of a psychological barrier to communication, when we are angry it is easy to say things that we may later regret and also to misinterpret what others are saying. More generally people with low self-esteem may be less assertive and therefore may not feel comfortable communicating - they may feel shy about saying how they really feel or read negative sub-texts into messages they hear.

- 3) **Physiological Barriers** Physiological barriers may result from the receiver's physical state: for example, a receiver with reduced hearing may not grasp to entirety of a spoken conversation especially if there is significant background noise.
- 4) **Physical Barriers.** An example of a physical barrier to communication is geographic distance between the sender and receiver(s). Communication is generally easier over shorter distances as more communication channels are available and less technology is required. Although modern technology often serves to reduce the impact of physical barriers, the advantages and disadvantages of each communication channel should be understood so that an appropriate channel can be used to overcome the physical barriers.
- 5) **Systemic Barriers.** Systemic barriers to communication may exist in structures and organizations where there are inefficient or inappropriate information systems and communication channels, or where there is a lack of understanding of the roles and responsibilities for communication. In such

organizations, individuals may be unclear of their role in the communication process and therefore not know what is expected of them.

- 6) **Attitudinal Barriers** Attitudinal barriers are behaviors or perceptions that prevent people from communicating effectively. Attitudinal barriers to communication may result from personality conflicts, poor management, and resistance to change or a lack of motivation. Effective receivers of messages should attempt to overcome their own attitudinal barriers to facilitate effective communication.

The following are some specific barriers to effective communication:

- (a) **Differences in Perception:** e.g. people of different ages, nationalities, cultures, education, occupation, sex, status, personality etc. - each have different perceptions. Thus, differences in perception are often the root of many of other barriers to communication. **Perceptual Bias/Different Perceptions:** Selective hearing e.g. avoids listening to what is unpleasant or what did not fit him/her pre-existing attitudes and values. Communication does not easily take place between people who have different perceptions. E.g. an employee listening to his manager talk about the importance of team work and its benefits but is not comfortable in the team would likely 'block' the message.
- (b) **Jumping to Conclusions:** "see what we expect to see, hear, what we expect to hear" rather than what is being said.
- (c) **Stereotyping:** treating all people as if they were the same. Thus, danger of discussing people and what they say/communicate. A good example is taking a whole community/religious group to be the same if there is one who has done wrong.
- (d) **Lack of Knowledge:** It is difficult to communicate effectively with someone who has a very different background from yours, or whose knowledge of the particular subject of discussion is considerably less than yours.
- (e) **Lack of interest:** The receiver's lack of interest in your message. Do not assume that everyone is as concerned about our interests as we are.
- (f) **Difficulties in Self-Expression:** Communicator has difficulty finding the words to carry ideas. This also goes with lack of confidence.

(g) **Emotions:** Any strong felt emotion of either receiver or communicator can also prove to be a serious barrier.

(h) **Personality:** Differences in people's personality can cause problems. Often our resulting behavior can then affect the behavior of the other person e.g. the issue of 'clash of personalities' is one of the most common causes of communication failure. Strong influences against personalities may make one accept or reject what is being said with due consideration.

(i) **Poor Listening Skills:** for example, a group/audience/receiver who is not used to sitting down and concentrating – therefore, message is not successfully communicated thus resulting in an inappropriate feedback.

(j) **Information Overload:** this results from giving too much details, facts in a very short period of time. This would mean that most of the message would not be communicated successfully.

(k) **Lack of Interest/Hostile attitude:** this occurs when an individual believes that the message being communicated is not for him/her, is a waste of valuable time, then the person's message will not get through

(l) **Lack of Understanding:** using 'big' words or unfamiliar words to the audience/receiver that they do not understand, words with symbolic meaning, different interpretations will lead to misunderstanding.

**Poor Timing:** The message must be delivered at the right time. E.g. Telephoning at lunch time and Friday afternoons may make it difficult to get through because the person you need is not available.

**Noise:** This is any sound/anything that is unwanted which interrupts a communication channel. The noise could be either:

- **Technical:** e.g. Interference on a mobile phone or fax not working

- **Physical:** too much activity in the area where communication is taking place
- **Psychological:** increased anxiety may interfere with ability to pay attention to the other speaker.

**Appearance of the Individual:** this may hinder communication if the audience is critical. A speaker with a dirty outfit/who is poorly dressed may not receive the favorable response from the audience.

**Distraction:** any upsetting factor which influences the human senses such as strong light/strong smell will hinder effective communication.

**Mistrust:** when the parties in the business of communicating do not trust one another and there is no goodwill. Effective communication will be hindered.

- (m) **Distance:** distances are factors in communication. When the place to be communicated to is very far/the people are far apart, weak signals may not reach easily. Therefore communication is hindered. However, the effect of distance can be countered by information technology where satellite disks can be used for long distance communication.
- (n) **Geographical Features:** these can hinder communication in that mountains, rivers, ranges, valleys, lakes and oceans do separate people/area and again this can easily overcome through modern technology.
- (o) **Different Status:** communication take place easily between people with different status within the organization/school etc. (rich-poor etc)

## **STRATEGIES OF OVERCOMING BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION**

Unless we overcome the barriers that make us not communicate, more barriers will be created. The following are some of the ways of overcoming the barriers:

- (i) **Face-to-Face:** This will allow for constant adjustment of the message to ensure that the message is received well.
- (ii) **Being sensitive** to the other person'/people's backgrounds. E.g. where the person grew, tribe, culture, language and level of education.
- (iii) **The use of direct, simple** and unambiguous language while taking care of words with symbolic meaning.
- (iv) **The use of frequent repetition;** restatement and reinforcement/follow-up to ensure the message is properly understood.
- (v) **Being supportive** to counter any defensive attitude – continued support will help the communication process

- (vi) **Being a good listener:** this will encourage the communicator to continue giving the message.
- (vii) **Put away any mistrust,** prejudice bias and misunderstanding to ensure you communicate and interpret the message clearly.
- (viii) **using appropriate channels** of communication that keeps the noise levels low
- (ix) **By developing interest** in the subject of communication and preparing oneself for the same.
- (x) **By using modern technology** methods which enables not only faster communication but also over great distances and geographical barriers.

**Conclusion:** the above stated are only a few of the many factors which can cause communication to be less effective or even fail completely. It is up to either the receiver of the communication/sender to make conditions as satisfactory as possible so that communication – a far from perfect process stands a chance of being effective.

**Question: Explain how you can overcome the following barriers in communication process:**

- **Stereotyping**
- **Noise**
- **Language**

**UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

**COURSE: ALL COURSES**

**LESSON 5: ESSENTIALS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION**

**Objectives: At the end of the lesson, the students should:**

**ESSENTIALS OF EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION**

For communication to take place, there are those items that must be available (those that cannot be done away with) the following are such essentials:

(a)**The Subject:** the subject is also known as the content of the message. This is the information that you would like your receiver to understand. Ask yourself of

the following questions before you send the message or initiate the process of communication:

WHAT exactly do you want to say?

What exactly do you need to say?

What does your audience want to know?

(b)**The Audience:** This is the receiver of the message. It is important to have enough information about the audience. For example, you need to know their personality, age status, education, political inclinations, marital status etc. It is important to gauge how they are likely to react to the content of your message.

(c)**Purpose of Communication:** this requires that you ask yourself the following questions:

(i)Why am I communicating?

(ii)What is my real reason for writing, speaking or gesticulating?

(iii)What do I hope to achieve? Is it to change the attitude of the audience, or change their opinion?

(iv)What do I want the audience to do as a result of my communication? In other words, do I want to persuade, inform, influence, educate, advice, entertain, provoke, stimulate thought or castigate?

(d)**Appropriate Channel:** A channel is a vehicle by which the message is passed on to the audience. For you to select/choose an appropriate channel, ask yourself: Am I going to communicate by use of words, pictures or both? Which medium would be the most appreciated by the audience – written or spoken, a letter or personal chat?

**Proper Presentation/Packaging:** This the means by which you will achieve the most desired response from the audience. Ask yourself: what is the best way to organize the points you want to drive home to your audience? What words should you use to create the right effect? How will you use stress and intonation to deliver the message appropriately?

## CHANNELS OF COMMUNICATION

A channel is a vehicle by which the message is passed on to the audience. In official circles, information is normally passed through two channels. These are

formal and informal. Workplace communication is the process of exchanging information, both verbal and non-verbal, within an organization. An organization may consist of employees from different parts of the society.

In order to unite the activities of all employees, communication is crucial. Communicating necessary information to the entire workforce becomes necessary. Effective workplace communication ensures that all the organizational objectives are achieved.

- i. **Formal Communication.** Formal communication - written or oral - follows the chain of command of the formal organization; the communication flows from the manager to his immediate subordinates. Each recipient then re-transmits the message in the selected form to the next lower level of management or to staff members, as appropriate. The message progresses down the chain of command, fanning out along the way, until all who have a need to know are informed. Formal communication also flows upward through the organization on the same basis.

Formal communication normally encompasses the transmittal of goals, policies, instructions, memoranda, and reports; scheduled meetings; and supervisory-subordinate interviews.

How does an organization chart aid formal communication?

Formal communication refers to interchange of information officially. The flow of communication is controlled and is a deliberate effort. This makes it possible for the information to reach the desired place without any hindrance, at a little cost and in a proper way. This is also known as 'Through Proper Channel Communication.'

## **Characteristics**

Following are the chief characteristics of the formal communication:

(1) **Written and Oral:** Formal communication can both be written and oral. Daily works are handled through oral communication, while the policy matters require written communication.

(2) **Formal Relations:** This communication is adopted among those employees where formal relations have been established by the organization. The sender and the receiver have some sort of organizational relations.

(3) **Prescribed Path:** The communication has to pass through a definite channel while moving from one person to another. For example, to convey the feelings of a worker to the manager, the foreman's help has to be sought.

(4) **Organizational Message:** This channel is concerned with the authorized organizational messages only and the personal messages are out of its jurisdiction.

(5) **Deliberate Effort:** This channel of communication is not established automatically but effort has to be made for its creation. It is decided keeping in view the objectives of the organization.

## **Advantages of formal communication**

(1) **Maintenance of Authority of the Officers:** Formal communication maintains constant relations among the superiors and the subordinates as a result of whom the dignity of the line superiors is maintained. Consequently, it is convenient to control the subordinates and fix their responsibility which is absolutely needed for effective and successful control.

(2) **Clear and Effective Communication:** In formal communication, there is a direct contact among the managers and the subordinates. Both understand the capability, habits, feelings, etc. of one another. Managers know as to when and under which conditions their subordinates need information. In this way, this communication is capable of making available timely information. Hence, it is clear and effective.

(3) **Orderly Flow of Information:** The information has to pass through a definite route from one person to another. Hence, the flow of information is systematic.

(4) **Easy Knowledge of Source of Information:** In this type of communication, the source of each information can be easily located.

## **Limitations/disadvantages**

(1) **Overload of Work:** In a modern business organization much information, many messages and other things have to be communicated. Under formal communication, they are routed through a definite channel and this consumes much of the time of the superiors and thus some other important works are left unattended.

(2) **Distortion of Information:** This method can be a hindrance in the flow of information. Sometimes the distance between the sender and the receiver is so big

that the information has to pass through many hands and by the time it reaches the receiver it is distorted. Thus it fails to serve its purpose.

(3) **Indifferent Officers:** The officers do not pay much attention to the suggestions and complaints of the subordinates. In such a case a subordinate may come lose his faith in the effectiveness of communication.

## ii. **Informal Communication**

- ❖ No organization operates in a completely formal or structured environment. Communication between operations depicted in an organizational chart do not function as smoothly or as trouble-free as the chart may imply. In most organizations operating effectively, channels of communication have developed outside the hierarchical structure.
- ❖ The informal communication process supplements the formal process by filling the gaps and/or omissions. Successful managers encourage informal organizational linkages and, at the same time, recognize that circumvention of established lines of authority and communication is not a good regular practice. When lines of authority have been bypassed, the manager must assume responsibility for informing those normally in the chain of command of the action taken.
- ❖ There is a fine line between using informal communications to expedite the work of the organization and the needless bypassing of the chain of command. The expediting process gets the job done, but bypassing the chain of command causes irritation and can lead to hard feelings. To be effective, the manager must find a way to balance formal and informal communication processes.

## iii. **Grapevine Communication**

The "grapevine" is a part of the unofficial communication process in any organization.

A grapevine arises because of lack of information employees consider important: organizational changes, jobs, or associates. This rumor mill transmits information of highly varying accuracy at a remarkable speed. Rumors tend to fall into three categories: those reflecting anxiety, those involving things hoped for, and those causing divisiveness in the organization. Some rumors fade with the passing of time; others die when certain events occur.

Employees take part in the grapevine process to the extent that they form groups. Any employee not considered a part of some group is apt to be left out of this unofficial communication process.

The grapevine is not necessarily good or bad. It serves a useful function when it acts as a barometer of employees' feelings and attitudes. Unfortunately, the information traveling along the grapevine tends to become magnified or exaggerated. Employees then become alarmed unnecessarily by what they hear. It is imperative that a manager be continually alert to the circulation of false information. When discovered, positive steps should be taken to provide the correct information immediately.

Informal communication is also called grapevine communication because there is no definite channel of communication. Under it some information passes through many individuals and covers a long distance making its origin obscure. This is **exactly like a grapevine where it is difficult to find the beginning and the end.**

## **Characteristics**

Informal or grapevine communication has the following characteristics:

### **(1) Formation through Social Relations:**

This communication is born out of social relations who mean that it is beyond the restrictions of the organization. No superior-subordinate relationship figures therein. A more sociable superior can gather much information through this channel.

**(2) Uncertain Path:** Since it is beyond the restrictions of the organization, it follows no definite channel. Like a grapevine, it moves in a zigzag manner.

**(3) Possibility of Rumor and Distortion:** Responsibility for the true or false nature of communication does not lie on any individual and, therefore, not much attention is paid to its meaning while communicating. Consequently, the rumors keep floating.

**(4) Quick Relay:** Informal communication makes news spread like wildfire. Not only this, people start adding something of their own which sometimes changes the real meaning of the communication.

## **Advantages**

The informal channel of communication has the following advantages:

- (1) **Fast and Effective Communication:** Under this communication, the messages move fast and their effect is equally great on the people.
- (2) **Free Environment:** Informal communication is done in a free environment. Free environment means that there is no pressure of any office-big or small. The reactions of the employees can easily be collected.
- (3) **Better Human Relations:** Informal communication saves the employees from tension. Freedom from tension helps the establishment of better human relations. This also affects the formal communication.
- (4) **Easy Solution of the Difficult Problems:** There are many problems which cannot be solved with the help of formal communication. There is more freedom in informal communication which helps the solution of difficult problems.
- (5) **Satisfying the Social Needs of the Workers:** Everybody wants good relations with the high officers at the place of his work. Such relations give satisfaction to the employees and they feel proud. But this can be possible only with the help of the informal communication.
6. **Grapevine channels carry information rapidly.** As soon as an employee gets to know some confidential information, he becomes inquisitive and passes the details then to his closest friend who in turn passes it to other. Thus, it spreads hastily.
7. The managers get to know the reactions of their subordinates on their policies. Thus, the **feedback obtained is quick compared** to formal channel of communication.
8. The grapevine **creates a sense of unity** among the employees who share and discuss their views with each other. Thus, grapevine helps in developing group cohesiveness.
9. The grapevine serves as an **emotional supportive value**. Employees are able to express what is in their mind without fear and through the interaction, they relieve any stress that they have.

## Limitations

The defects or limitations of the informal communication are as under:

- (1) **Unsystematic Communication:**

This communication is absolutely unsystematic and it is not necessary that information reaches the person concerned.

## (2) **Unreliable Information:**

Most of the information received through this communication is undependable and no important decision can be taken on its basis.

(3) The grapevine is a supplement in those cases where formal communication does not work. **The grapevine carries partial information at times as it is more based on rumors.** Thus, it does not clearly depict the complete state of affairs.

(4) The grapevine is **not trustworthy always as it does not follow official path** of communication and is spread more by gossips and unconfirmed report.

(5) The **productivity of employees may be hampered** as they spend more time talking rather than working.

(6) The grapevine **leads to making hostility** against the executives.

(7) The grapevine may hamper **the goodwill of the organization** as it may carry false negative information about the high level people of the organization.

**N/B** A smart manager should take care of all the disadvantages of the grapevine and try to minimize them. At the same time, he should make best possible use of advantages of grapevine.

## **TYPES OF COMMUNICATION**

### **(1) Vertical Communication**

Vertical communication is of the following two types:

1. **Downward Communication:** The communication by top hierarchy with their subordinates is called downward communication. This communication includes orders, rules, information, policies, instructions, etc.

The chief advantage of the downward communication is that the subordinates get useful timely information which helps them in their work performance, Downward Flow of Communication: Communication that flows from a higher level in an organization to a lower level is a downward communication.

In other words, communication from superiors to subordinates in a chain of command is a downward communication. This communication flow is used by the managers to transmit work-related information to the employees at lower levels. Employees require this information for performing their jobs and for meeting the expectations of their managers.

## **PURPOSES OF DOWNWARD COMMUNICATION**

- a) Providing feedback on employees performance
- b) Giving job instructions
- c) Providing a complete understanding of the employee's job as well as to communicate them how their job is related to other jobs in the organization.
- d) Communicating the organizations mission and vision to the employees.
- e) Highlighting the areas of attention.

Organizational publications, circulars, letter to employees, group meetings etc. are all examples of downward communication.

In order to have effective and error-free downward communication, managers must:

- Specify communication objective,
- Ensure that the message is accurate, specific and unambiguous and
- Utilize the best communication technique to convey the message to the receiver in right form

**2. Upward Communication:** This is quite the reverse of the downward communication. This flows from the subordinates to the superiors. The subject-matter of this communication includes suggestions, reactions, reports, complaints, etc. This sort of communication helps the superiors in taking decisions.

**Upward Flow of Communication:** Communication that flows to a higher level in an organization is called upward communication. It provides feedback on how well the organization is functioning. The subordinates use upward communication to convey their problems and performances to their superiors.

The subordinates also use upward communication to tell how well they have understood the downward communication. It can also be used by the employees to share their views and ideas and to participate in the decision-making process.

Upward communication leads to a more committed and loyal workforce in an organization because the employees are given a chance to raise and speak dissatisfaction issues to the higher levels. The managers get to know about the employees feelings towards their jobs, peers, supervisor and organization in general. Managers can thus accordingly take actions for improving things.

Grievance Redressal System, Complaint and Suggestion Box, Job Satisfaction surveys etc. all help in improving upward communication. Other examples of Upward Communication are -performance reports made by low level management for reviewing by higher level management, employee attitude surveys, letters from employees, employee-manager discussions etc.

**3. Horizontal Communication:** Horizontal communication takes place when two individuals of the same level exchange information. Horizontal communication is used by the same level officers to solve the problems of similar nature and profit by the experience of other people.

The subject-matter of horizontal communication includes information, requests, suggestions, mutual problems and coordination-related information.

Horizontal Communication (ALSO KNOWN AS LATERAL): Communication that takes place at same levels of hierarchy in an organization is called lateral communication, i.e., communication between peers, between managers at same levels or between any horizontally equivalent organizational members

### **ADVANTAGES OF HORIZONTAL COMMUNICATION**

- ❖ It is time saving.
- ❖ It facilitates co-ordination of the task.
- ❖ It facilitates co-operation among team members.
- ❖ It provides emotional and social assistance to the organizational members.
- ❖ It helps in solving various organizational problems.
- ❖ It is a means of information sharing
- ❖ It can also be used for resolving conflicts of a department with other department or conflicts within a department.

**4. Diagonal Communication:** Communication that takes place between a manager and employees of other workgroups is called diagonal communication. It generally does not appear on organizational chart. For instance - To design a training module

a training manager interacts with an Operations personnel to enquire about the way they perform their task.

5. **External Communication:** Communication that takes place between a manager and external groups such as - suppliers, vendors, banks, financial institutes etc. For instance - To raise capital the Managing director would interact with the Bank Manager.

## FORMS OF COMMUNICATION

- 1) Verbal Communication-
- 2) Written Communication
- 3) Nonverbal Communication
- 4) Visual (audio-visual)

### Verbal Communication

Verbal communication refers to the form of communication in which message is transmitted verbally; communication is done by word of mouth. Objective of every communication is to have people understand what we are trying to convey. In verbal communication remember the acronym KISS (keep it short and simple).

When we talk to others, we assume that others understand what we are saying because we know what we are saying. But this is not the case. Usually, people bring their own attitude, perception, emotions and thoughts about the topic and hence creates barrier in delivering the right meaning.

So in order to deliver the right message, you must put yourself on the other side of the table and think from your receiver's point of view. Would he understand the message? How would it sound on the other side of the table?

In oral communication, Spoken words are used. It includes face-to-face conversations, speech, telephonic conversation, video, radio, television, voice over internet. In oral communication, communication is influenced by pitch, volume, speed and clarity of speaking.

**Advantages of Oral communication are:**

- a) It brings quick feedback. In a face-to-face conversation, by reading facial expression and body language one can guess whether he/she should trust what's being said or not. Other advantages include:
- b) There is high level of understanding and transparency in oral communication as it is interpersonal.
- c) There is no element of rigidity in oral communication. There is flexibility for allowing changes in the decisions previously taken.
- d) The feedback is spontaneous in case of oral communication. Thus, decisions can be made quickly without any delay.
- e) Oral communication is not only time saving, but it also saves upon money and efforts.
- f) Oral communication is best in case of problem resolution. The conflicts, disputes and many issues/differences can be put to an end by talking them over.
- g) Oral communication is an essential for teamwork and group energy.
- h) Oral communication promotes a receptive and encouraging morale among organizational employees.
- i) Oral communication can be best used to transfer private and confidential information/matter. (not always)

.

. It brings personal warmth and friendliness and develops a sense of bonding because of these contacts between the people.

## **Disadvantages of oral communication**

- a) `In face-to-face discussion, user is unable to deeply think about what he is delivering. Other disadvantages include:
- b) Relying only on oral communication may not be sufficient as business communication is formal and very organized.
- c) Oral communication is less authentic than written communication as they are informal and not as organized as written communication.
- d) Oral communication is time-saving as far as daily interactions are concerned, but in case of meetings, long speeches consume lot of time and are unproductive at times.
- e) Oral communications are not easy to maintain and thus they are unsteady.
- f) There may be misunderstandings as the information is not complete and may lack essentials.

- g) It requires attentiveness and great receptivity on part of the receivers/audience
- h) Information retention is difficult, it is harder to store or retrieve. The 80-20 rule comes into play here-the majority of the audience is likely to forget 80% of the information, while retaining only 20%- thus making the speaker's task very difficult.
- i) Selective hearing, receiving information may be distorted resulting in miscommunication.

## **WRITTEN COMMUNICATION**

In written communication, written signs or symbols are used to communicate. A written message may be printed or hand written.

In written communication message can be transmitted via **email, letter, report, memo** etc. Message, in written communication, is influenced by the vocabulary & grammar used, writing style, precision and clarity of the language used.

Written Communication is most common form of communication being used in business. So, it is considered core among business skills.

Memos, reports, bulletins, job descriptions, employee manuals, and electronic mail are the types of written communication used for internal communication. For communicating with external environment in writing, electronic mail, Internet Web sites, letters, proposals, telegrams, faxes, postcards, contracts, advertisements, brochures, and news releases are used.

### **Advantages of written communication includes:**

- a) Messages can be edited and revised many time before it is actually sent.
- b) Written communication provides record for every message sent and can be saved for later study.
- c) A written message enables receiver to fully understand it and send appropriate feedback.

### **Disadvantages of written communication includes:**

- a) Unlike oral communication, written communication doesn't bring instant feedback.

- b) It takes more time in composing a written message as compared to word-of-mouth.
- c) A number of people struggles for writing ability.

## Nonverbal Communication

Nonverbal communication is the sending or receiving of wordless messages. We can say that communication other than oral and written, such as gesture, body language, posture, tone of voice or facial expressions, is called nonverbal communication. Nonverbal communication is all about the body language of speaker. They include:

- 1) **Kinesics Communication.** Kinesics communication is communicating by body movement and is perhaps the most well-known non-verbal form of communication, although it is not the only way to talk with others without words.
- 2) **Body posture.** The way we sit or stand communicates a lot. An open body that takes up a lot of space can indicate comfort and domination, whilst a closed-in body that makes itself small can signal inferiority.
- 3) **Gestures**

Gesture is communicating through the movement of body and arms.

Ekman and Friesen (1969) identified five types of gesture:

- Emblems: Direct replacements for words.
- Illustrators: Shaping what is being said.
- Affect displays: shows of emotion.
- Regulators: for controlling the flow of conversation.
- Adaptors: Self-oriented tension relievers and other forms.

## 4) Facial signals

When we communicate with others, we look mostly at their face. This is not a coincidence as many signals are sent with the 90-odd muscles in the face. The way the head tilts also changes the message.

The eyes are particularly important, and when communicating we first seek to make eye contact. We then break and re-establish contact many times during the discussion.

Eyebrows and forehead also add significant signals, from surprise to fear to anger.

The mouth, when not talking can be pursed, downturned or turned up in a smile.

## Facial Expressions

Facial expressions are responsible for a huge proportion of nonverbal communication. Consider how much information can be conveyed with a smile or a frown. The look on a person's face is often the first thing we see, even before we hear what they have to say.

While nonverbal communication and behavior can vary dramatically between cultures, the facial expressions for happiness, sadness, anger, and fear are similar throughout the world.

Nonverbal communication helps receiver in interpreting the message received. Often, nonverbal signals reflects the situation more accurately than verbal messages. Sometimes nonverbal response contradicts verbal communication and hence affect the effectiveness of message.

Nonverbal communication has the following three elements:

### 5) Appearance

Speaker: clothing, hairstyle, neatness, use of cosmetics

Surrounding: room size, lighting, decorations, furnishings

Our choice of color, clothing, hairstyles, and other factors affecting appearance are also considered a means of nonverbal communication. Research on color psychology has demonstrated that different colors can evoke different moods. Appearance can also alter physiological reactions, judgments, and interpretations.

Just think of all the subtle judgments you quickly make about someone based on his or her appearance. These first impressions are important, which is why experts suggest that job seekers dress appropriately for interviews with potential employers.

Researchers have found that appearance can play a role in how people are perceived and even how much they earn. One 1996 study found that attorneys who

were rated as more attractive than their peers earned nearly 15 percent more than those ranked as less attractive. Culture is an important influence on how appearances are judged. While thinness tends to be valued in Western cultures, some African cultures relate full-figured bodies to better health, wealth, and social status.

## **5. Body Language**

Facial expressions, gestures, postures e.tc. Posture and movement can also convey a great deal of information. Research on body language has grown significantly since the 1970s, but popular media have focused on the over-interpretation of defensive postures, arm-crossing, and leg-crossing, especially after publishing Julius Fast's book Body Language.

While these nonverbal behaviors can indicate feelings and attitudes, research suggests that body language is far more subtle and less definitive than previously believed.

## **6. Paralinguistic**

Paralinguistic refers to vocal communication that is separate from actual language. This includes factors such as tone of voice, loudness, inflection, and pitch.

Consider the powerful effect that tone of voice can have on the meaning of a sentence. When said in a strong tone of voice, listeners might interpret approval and enthusiasm. The same words said in a hesitant tone of voice might convey disapproval and a lack of interest.

Consider all the different ways that simply changing your tone of voice might change the meaning of a sentence. A friend might ask you how you are doing, and you might respond with the standard "I'm fine," but how you actually say those words might reveal a tremendous amount of how you are really feeling.

A cold tone of voice might suggest that you are actually not fine, but you don't wish to discuss it. A bright, happy tone of voice will reveal that you are actually doing quite well. A somber, downcast tone would indicate that you are the opposite of fine and that perhaps your friend should inquire further.

## **7. Proxemics**

People often refer to their need for "personal space," which is also an important type of nonverbal communication.

The amount of distance we need and the amount of space we perceive as belonging to us is influenced by a number of factors including social norms, cultural expectations, situational factors, personality characteristics, and level of familiarity.

The amount of personal space needed when having a casual conversation with another person usually varies between 18 inches to four feet. On the other hand, the personal distance needed when speaking to a crowd of people is around 10 to 12 feet.

## **8. Haptic**

Communicating through touch is another important nonverbal behavior. There has been a substantial amount of research on the importance of touch in infancy and early childhood.

Touch can be used to communicate affection, familiarity, sympathy, and other emotions.

In her book *Interpersonal Communication: Everyday Encounters*, author Julia Wood writes that touch is also often used as a way to communicate both status and power.

Researchers have found that high-status individuals tend to invade other people's personal space with greater frequency and intensity than lower-status individuals. Sex differences also play a role in how people utilize touch to communicate meaning.

Women tend to use touch to convey care, concern, and nurturance. Men, on the other hand, are more likely to use touch to assert power or control over others.

## **9. Eye Gaze**

The eyes play an important role in nonverbal communication and such things as looking, staring and blinking are important nonverbal behaviors. When people encounter people or things that they like, the rate of blinking increases and pupils dilate. Looking at another person can indicate a range of emotions including hostility, interest, and attraction.

People also utilize eye gaze as a means to determine if someone is being honest. Normal, steady eye contact is often taken as a sign that a person is telling the truth and is trustworthy. Shifty eyes and an inability to maintain eye contact, on the other hand, is frequently seen as an indicator that someone is lying or being deceptive.

## **Visual Communication:**

“It is easier to see with your eyes than with your mind.”

- Visual communication is a more concrete way of communicating where pictures and text are often used together. You can use illustrations, photos, sketches, symbols, and texts. This is a way of communicating that becomes more specific and doesn't allow for misunderstandings to the same degree as the spoken language. That's why we use contracts or manuals when we want to be extremely clear and completely avoid misunderstandings.
- Visual communication as the name suggests is communication through visual aid and is described as the conveyance of ideas and information in forms that can be read or looked upon. Visual communication in part or whole relies on vision, and is primarily presented or expressed with two dimensional images, it includes: signs,

## **Benefits**

- **Immediacy**

One of the primary benefits from visual communication over verbal is immediacy. Think back to the last time you tried to explain something complex to a friend, coworker, family member, more often than not in these situations you spend long periods of time making sure your audience understands what it is you're explaining. Now, contrast that experience with looking at a chart explaining the sales for a specific product, you can show that information almost instantaneously. Visual Communication can bring a thing, location and even an idea to life in dynamic ways.

- **Simplicity**

Another advantage is simplicity. Often visual communication can simplify the information of ideas that you are seeking to pass on to others. For example,

architects use visual diagrams and schematics to pass on valuable information to contractors in a quick, easy to understand manner. Visual communication can also demonstrate the relationship between two entities or ideas in accessible ways.

- **Flexibility**

Visual communication can also be more flexible in many ways than verbal communication. Visual communication not only bridges geographic distances, it can span cultural references. If you are looking to appeal to a broad demographic audience, such as a television or cable audience, visual images may allow you to reach more people with your message. Appealing visual images will often be more persuasive than verbal pitches.

### **Limitations of Visual Aids**

- If a visual aid is not properly designed for its intended use and audience, it can lead to a breakdown in communication. For example, a business person presenting a new product launch must consider the size and color of the product images he wants to show to the audience. The size of his audience determines the size of the pictures he will present. A large audience requires large images that might be shown on a screen so they are visible by everyone. A small audience, such as one that can be seated around a conference room table, can be shown images from a brochure.
- A visual aid with the wrong information can cause a distraction and detract from the message the image is supposed to convey. For example, a discussion of a company's manufacturing plants might be accompanied by a map showing the location of these plants within their respective counties. . But if you include irrelevant information, such as tourist sites, it can distract the audience from the purpose of the map – to show the location of manufacturing plants.
- sometimes the speaker relies too much on the visuals and doesn't present the material as well as they could,
- If a visual aid is not properly designed for its intended use and audience, it can lead to a breakdown in communication.

Audio-visual communication involves the use of what one can see and hear as well. This can be seen in films, power point presentations, television presentations – news/bulletins etc. To employ audio-visual aids in communication enhances communication at all spheres.

Next time you are trying to convey large, complex information to a group of people think about the advantages of doing so visually. This way you will be certain that your audience will leave with a solid understanding of what you're trying to convey. Also, you will be saved from frustration when you're forced to repeat yourself to make you point better understood. Typography, drawing, graphic design, illustration, colour

## **UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

### **COURSE: ALL COURSES**

#### **LESSON 10: WRITING SKILLS**

**OBJECTIVES:** At the end of the lesson, the student should:

- Understand the use of punctuation marks in written document
- Explain the importance of courtesy in writing
- Be able to develop a well-constructed paragraphs

## **INTRODUCTION**

Writing is an important skill to convey meaning. In their writing, people may write well but struggle from the fear of punctuation and grammar. They know how to pre-write, organize, and revise, but proofreading for punctuation and grammar causes them difficulties. The rules of punctuation are created and maintained by writers to help make their prose more effective, and their exact meaning changes over time. This topic discusses the most useful punctuation marks that are used in writing.

## **Punctuation**

They are the marks, such as full stop, comma, and brackets, used in writing to separate sentences and their elements and to clarify meaning.

Punctuation marks are pauses or gestures used to clarify the meaning of our words. "They are signals to the reader that indicate pause, place emphasis, alter the function or show the relationship between the elements of the text." (Jane, 2008:122)

Punctuation is also used to create sense, clarity and stress in sentences. You use punctuation marks to structure and organize your writing.

## **PUNCTUATION MARKS IN WRITING**

- comma (,)
- To separate items in the same list. E.g. she travelled to America , Canada, and Australia.

- To separate phrases in apposition (describing the same Person or thing mentioned earlier) from the rest of sentence. E.g. Mr. Brown, the doctor, said that he travelled to Canada.
- Commas are used to separate adjectives. For example: The boy was happy, eager and full of anticipation at the start of his summer holiday.
- **Full stop (.)**
  - A full stop is used at the end of the sentence. The full stop indicates that a point has been made and that you are about to move on to further explanations or a related point. e.g. Ali felt tired. He went to bed.
  - An abbreviation ends in a full stop and with acronyms. E.g. etc. Mr. B.B.C.
- **Colon (:)**
  - The use of a colon indicates that what follows is an explanation of what precedes it. e.g. They have some news about the story: John's father has arrived.
  - It is also used to introduce a list of the items. e.g. To travel, you need the following items: a passport, a visa, an application and the correct fee
- **Semi colon (;)**
  - A semi colon is used to join two independent but related clauses or sentences. e.g. She is a good writer; she has published several books.
  - It can also separate clauses of conjunctive adverbs such as however, therefore, moreover... e.g. We shouldn't go to the fair; however, I do hear that they have good funnel cakes.
- **Quotation mark ("")**
  - Quotation marks are used for material that is quoted or emphasized. e.g. Ali said, "I cannot finish my homework."
  - Quotation marks are used to set off the title of short works of writing. e.g. The television show, "American got talent."
- **Apostrophe ('')**
  - An apostrophe is used to refer to possessive singular or plural. e.g. The **boy's** books. (Singular) e.g. The boys' books. (plural)
  - An apostrophe is used always to be included when telling the time. e.g. It is eight **o'clock**. \*short for: (eight of the clock)
  - An apostrophe is used to show letters are missing in words (omission). e.g. **you're**→ You are.
- **Exclamation mark (!)**
  - An exclamation mark is used to signal the expression of a strong emotions such as:  
A-Excitement: e.g. I can't wait!  
B-Panic: e.g. Help me!

# CYNTHIA NYABOKE MATARA - 0793966955

- An exclamation mark is used to add an emphasis to the sentence. e.g. There's a fly in my Soup!
- **Ellipsis (...)**
  - An ellipsis is used to show that the speaker has been cut off abruptly (interrupted). e.g. 'Whatever you do, don't...'
  - An ellipsis is used to indicate a trailing off in speech or thought. e.g. We could do this ... or maybe that...
- **slash (/)**
  - Slash is used with fractions. e.g.  $1/2$  = one-half e. g.  $2/3$  = two-third
  - Use a slash to separate the day, month, and a year in dates. e.g. He was born on 18/3/1987
- **Question mark (?)**
  - Used at the end of any direct questions. e.g. Who is your teacher?
  - Use a question mark at the end of a tag question (a statement followed by a short question). e.g. You speak English, don't you?
- **Hyphen (-)**
  - A hyphen may separate, in some cases, the prefix from the second part of words. e.g. co-opt, T-shirt.
  - A hyphen may join some compound words. e.g. twenty-one.
- **Parentheses (( ))**
  - Parentheses or brackets are often used to include extra or additional information into a sentence. e.g. The library (which was built in the seventeenth century) needs to be repaired.
  - Parentheses give additional, but non-essential information in a sentence. e.g. France, America, and Spanish (but not Chinese) may be studied here.
- **Square Brackets ([ ] )**
  - Square brackets are used for clarification, to help the reader understand the sentence. e.g. She drove 60 [mile per hour] on the highway to town.
- **Dash (Em—Dash, En—Dash)**
  - Em—Dash is used to indicate a break, often informally, or to add Parenthetical information .e.g. They received a prize —and a certificate as well.
  - An En—Dash is used to indicate a range. e.g. 1939—1945

**The Test: Punctuate the following sentences with suitable marks**

1. If you don t understand please tell me
2. Mr Jone the doctor said that he saw the patient

**INCOMING CONGRESSLADY - 0793966955**

3. She wants a book papers and a ruler
4. The letter has arrived He sat down to read it
5. Whatever you do don t
6. We could do this or maybe that
7. Who is your teacher
8. You speak English don t you
9. T shirt

## REFERENCE:

- 1) Jane S. (2008): The Blue Book of Grammar and Punctuation. Jossey-Bass A Wiley Imprint, the United States of America.
- 2) Snooks, O. (2002): Style manual for authors, editors and printers. Canberra: AGPS Press.
- 3) Truss, L. (2003). Eats, Shoots and Leaves: The Zero Tolerance Approach to Punctuation. Albany: New York.
- 4) [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/339297516 Punctuation Marks in English](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/339297516_Punctuation_Marks_in_English)

## IMPORTANCE OF COURTESY IN WRITING

### INTRODUCTION

Courtesy means being polite and treating others with equal respect as you would treat yourself. This calls for a considerate and friendly attitude towards the other the receiver.

All communicators should demonstrate courtesy by following these methods:

- Develop the you attitude.
- Use positive words.
- Select gender-free terms.
- Respond to messages promptly.

## Importance of courtesy

- 1) Courtesy helps you maintain goodwill by showing concern for the reader. Goodwill is a feeling of confidence based on honesty and reliable service.
- 2) It helps the reader understand exactly what you intend to communicate because many decisions depend entirely on the written word. A misused or misunderstood word can confuse the reader and cost a business money.
- 3) Positive words show respect for the reader and reflect the you attitude. People are more open to the content of positive messages than of negative ones
- 4) It enhances the effectiveness of written communication. A favorable business reputation is built on orders that are shipped early. In addition, a timely response may turn a complaint into a business opportunity.
- 5) It validates their existence as human beings and affirms that even the smallest gesture has not gone unnoticed. Even if a customer expects nothing in return from you, the simple courtesy of expressing your gratitude in writing for just supporting your efforts with their patronage not only encourages ongoing loyalty but creates a chain reaction of paying kindness forward to others.

## PARAGRAPH DEVELOPMENT

A paragraph is a collection of sentences which all relate to one main idea or topic .It should be unified, coherent, and well-developed. Typically, you want to keep one idea to one paragraph.

Effective paragraphs have four main characteristics:

- A topic sentence,
- Unity,
- Coherence,
- And adequate development.

### 1. Topic Sentence:

The topic sentence expresses the main point of the paragraph. The topic sentence is typically the first sentence of the paragraph. It helps your reader to understand what the topic of your paragraph is going to be. The purpose of the topic sentence is to state the main point of the paragraph and to give the paragraph a sense of direction.

### 2. Unity

Unity refers to the extent to which all of the ideas contained within a given paragraph "hang together" in a way that is easy for the reader to understand. When the writer changes to a new idea -- one which is not consistent with the topic sentence of the paragraph -- the writer should begin a new paragraph. Unity is important because it aids the reader in following along with the writer's ideas. The reader can expect that a given paragraph will deal only with one main topic; when a new paragraph begins, this signals that the writer is moving on to a new topic.

Consider the following example. Note that there are two main ideas presented in this paragraph. The topic sentence indicates that the paragraph will deal with the subject of "employees' attitudes," but the paragraph shifts unexpectedly to the topic of "management's attitudes." To achieve unity in this paragraph, the writer should begin a new paragraph when the switch is made from employees to managers.

## **Example**

"Employees' attitudes at Jonstone Electric Company should be improved. The workers do not feel that they are a working team instead of just individuals. If people felt they were a part of a team, they would not misuse the tools, or deliberately undermine the work of others. Management's attitude toward its employees should also be improved. Managers at Jonstone Electric act as though their employees are incapable of making decisions or doing their own work. Managers treat workers like objects, not human beings."

## **3. Coherence**

Coherence refers to the extent to which the flow of ideas in a paragraph is easily understood by the reader. For this reason, coherence is closely related to unity. When a writer changes main ideas or topics within a paragraph, confusion often results. To achieve coherence, then, a writer should show how all of the ideas contained in a paragraph are relevant to the main topic.

Consider the example below. In this paragraph, the writer begins with the topic of job-skills courses, but veers off onto the topic of algebra and history before returning to the subject of courses on employment. As a result, the paragraph is disjointed and difficult to understand.

## **Example**

"Schools should offer courses to help students with the problems of unemployment. Such a course might begin with a discussion of where to find employment, then cover resume writing and interviewing. Algebra and history don't help students with real-world needs. They are required courses that students aren't interested in, and this is frustrating for students who would rather learn about other subjects. If schools offered job-skills courses, students would be well prepared for the difficult task of finding a job once they finish school."

A number of other techniques that you can use to establish coherence in paragraphs are described below:

## **TRANSITIONS**

- To show addition:

Again, and, also, besides, equally important, first (second, etc.), further, furthermore, in addition, in the first place, moreover, next, too

- To give examples:

For example, for instance, in fact, specifically, that is, to illustrate

- To compare:

Also, in the same manner, likewise, similarly

- To contrast:

Although, and yet, at the same time, but, despite, even though, however, in contrast, in spite of, nevertheless, on the contrary, on the other hand, still, though, yet

- To summarize or conclude:

All in all, in conclusion, in other words, in short, in summary, on the whole, that is, therefore, to sum up

- To show time:

After, afterward, as, as long as, as soon as, at last, before, during, earlier, finally, formerly, immediately, later, meanwhile, next, since, shortly, subsequently, then, thereafter, until, when, while

- To show place or direction:

Above, below, beyond, close, elsewhere, farther on, here, nearby, opposite, to the left (north, etc.)

- To indicate logical relationship:

Accordingly, as a result, because, consequently, for this reason, hence, if, otherwise, since, so, then, therefore, thus

#### 4. Adequate Development

It is important to fully develop and discuss the topic of your paragraph. If your paragraph is only 2-3 sentences, there is a good chance that you have not developed it enough.

Here are some ways you can develop and support your topic:

1. Use examples
2. Tell a story illustrating the idea
3. Compare and Contrast
4. Give data (such as facts, statistics, etc.)

#### PARAGRAPH STRUCTURE

Most paragraphs in an essay have a three-part structure—introduction, body, and conclusion. You can see this structure in paragraphs whether they are narrating, describing, comparing,

contrasting, or analyzing information. Each part of the paragraph plays an important role in communicating your meaning to your reader.

**Introduction:** the first section of a paragraph; should include the topic sentence and any other sentences at the beginning of the paragraph that give background information or provide a transition.

**Body:** follows the introduction; discusses the controlling idea, using facts, arguments, analysis, examples, and other information.

**Conclusion:** the final section; summarizes the connections between the information discussed in the body of the paragraph and the paragraph's controlling idea.

## UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS

### COURSE: ALL COURSES

#### LESSON 11: FUNCTIONAL WRITING

**OBJECTIVES:** At the end of the lesson, the student should:

- ❖ Write different types of essays
- ❖ Write different types of functional writing

## ESSAY WRITING

It is a short piece of writing that expresses information as well as the writer's opinion.

'Essay' is derived from a Latin word 'exagium', which roughly translates to presenting one's case. So essays are a short piece of writing representing one's side of the argument or one's experiences, stories, etc. Essays are very personalized.

The first step to writing an essay is to define what type of essay you are writing. There are **four main categories** into which essays can be grouped:

- a) Narrative Essay: Tell a story or impart information about your subject in a straightforward, orderly manner, like in a story.
- b) Persuasive Essay: Convince the reader about some point of view.
- c) Expository Essay: Explain to the reader how to do a given process. You could, for example, write an expository essay with step-by-step instructions on how to make a peanut butter sandwich.

- d) **Descriptive Essay:** Focus on the details of what is going on. For example, if you want to write a descriptive essay about your trip to the park, you would give great detail about what you experienced: how the grass felt beneath your feet, what the park benches looked like, and anything else the reader would need to feel as if he were there.

**e) argumentative essay**

This is the type of essay where you prove that your opinion, theory or hypothesis about an issue is correct or more truthful than those of others. In short, it is very similar to the persuasive essay (see above), but the difference is that you are arguing for your opinion as opposed to others, rather than directly trying to persuade someone to adopt your point of view.

## **What are its most important qualities?**

- The argument should be focused
- The argument should be a clear statement (a question cannot be an argument)
- It should be a topic that you can support with solid evidence
- The argumentative essay should be based on pros and cons (see below)
- Structure your approach well (see below)
- Use good transition words/phrases (see below)
- Be aware of your intended audience. How can you win them over?
- Research your topic so your evidence is convincing.
- Don't overdo your language and don't bore the reader. And don't keep repeating your points!
- Remember the rules of the good paragraph. One single topic per paragraph, and natural progression from one to the next.
- End with a strong conclusion.

## **To write an essay, there are three stages you need to follow:**

1. **Preparation:** Decide on your topic, do your research, and create an essay outline.
2. **Writing:** Set out your argument in the introduction, develop it with evidence in the main body, and wrap it up with a conclusion.
3. **Revision:** Check the content, organization, grammar, spelling, and formatting of your essay.

## **HOW TO WRITE A GOOD ESSAY**

- a Define the scope of essay e.g. if you are about the problems of industrialization the scope will be different from if you are to write about evils industrialization.

-In the 1st topic i.e. the problems of industrialization you will discuss about the availability of raw materials, energy, labour and market conditions etc.

-In the 2nd topic you can write about effects or industrialization e.g. pollution of atmosphere, exploitation of labour, concentration of wealth in few hands etc.

b Jot down the ideas

This means you put down relevant ideas in a sketch form.

c Prepare the outlines

You arrange the ideas you have generated in a logical sequence and you prepare your outline e.g. if you are writing about an event you should write using chorological sequences.

d Think of an attractive beginning

Introduction should be fresh, original and arresting. It should be strictly relevant to the subject.

e Conclusions have to be stated clearly and firmly.

f Develop different points in different paragraphs.

g Revise your essay

h Avoid being irrelevant.

i Use simple language

j Develop habit of reading newspapers and periodicals.

## FUNCTIONAL WRITING

Functional writing is the practice of expressing specific information meant to mirror real-life scenarios such as how to make or do something, giving advice or inviting someone to something. Functional writing often turns a complex subject into something that is more understandable to the reader.

## BUSINESS LETTERS

It is used for communication to persons outside the organization

### FUNCTIONS OF A BUSINESS LETTER.

- i) To provide a convenient and inexpensive means of communication without personal contact.
- ii) To seek or give information
- iii) To furnish evidence of transactions entered into
- iv) To provide a record for future reference.

v) To provide a written record and reference

## **CLASSIFICATION OF BUSINESS LETTERS**

-Business letters can be classified into:

- ❖ Letters of inquiry
- ❖ Letters answering a request
- ❖ Claim and adjustment letters
- ❖ Credit letters
- ❖ Collection letters
- ❖ Sales letters and
- ❖ Employment letters

## **ESSENTIALS OF EFFECTIVE BUSINESS LETTER**

### **1. Promptness**

Reply to the letter the day it is received. If time is needed acknowledge the letter and indicate when a reply will be sent.

### **2. Knowledge of the subject**

This includes knowledge of past correspondence.

### **3. Accuracy, completeness and clarity:**

Verify facts before you write them.

### **4. Courtesy**

We should seek favours politely and express our gratitude for the favours done to us.

### **5. Appropriateness**

Vary the tone of your letter according to the occasion and the psychology of the reader.

### **6. Tact**

You should endeavor to retain the goodwill of someone even though his request has been turned down.

### **7. Persuasion**

This means winning people to your point of view by making positive suggestions and explaining that what you say is to their advantage.

## **8. Conciseness**

Eliminate all irrelevant details from your letter.

## **9. Adopt the you approach**

Avoid the 'I' and 'We' in your letter.

## **10. Adopt the positive and pleasant Approach.**

Avoid saying no and sorry in your letter they are unpleasant and unwelcome No for example can be written as '

another time' or 'try later' sorry may be presented as 'I will try'.

## **11. Use familiar language**

Avoid jargon, bombastic and colloquial or words when writing a business letter.

## **PARTS OF A BUSINESS LETTER**

### **1. THE HEADING**

The heading is the letter head of the letter. It contains; the name of the organization, the logo, the address, the telephone number, fax number, e-mail, and the physical location of the business.

### **2. THE DATE**

The date comes below the heading. The date should have a format of either '30<sup>th</sup> October 2007' or 'October 30<sup>th</sup> 2007' the date should be underlined. For fully blocked letters the date comes at the left hand side. In case of semi blocked letter, it will appear at the right hand side of the paper.

### **3. ADDRESS**

The address of the person receiving the correspondence includes a formal name, street address, city, state, and zip code.

### **4. SALUTATION**

The salutation is the formal way of addressing the person.

Common salutations are Dear sir/madam or To Whom It May Concern.

Some people have sensitivities to what name is used in addressing them so be sure to take the time to identify the person's most commonly used name

## 6. THE BODY OF THE LETTER.

-The introduction section introduces the subject of the letter.

It is a summary in a sentence or two that explains the goal of the letter.

For example, an introduction may be something like:

I am writing to express my interest in a position you advertised.

-The body of the letter explains in detail all aspects of what is being communicated.

-This would include detail of the information being shared.

## 7. COMPLIMENTARY CLOSE

This is also referred to as *subscription*. It is a polite way of ending a letter.

Letters having salutations 'Dear Sir, Madam, Sirs, and madam' should end with 'yours faithfully'.  
Less formal letters can end 'yours truly' or 'yours very truly'.

Letters having Dear Mr. John should end 'yours sincerely'.

Letters to superiors can end 'yours respectfully'

## 8. SIGNATURE

The writer should sign by putting his/her name down and the position in the organization.

### 1. BLOCKED FORMAT

#### SAMPLE LETTERS

MANDASI BORA BAKERY LTD,

P.O Box 2198 Mombasa,

Tel...,

27th October 2007.

THE MANAGER, EQUITY BANK MOMBASA,

P.O Box 2849,

Mombasa.

Dear Sir,

**SUBJECT/ REF: APPLICATION FOR A LOAN**

I am greatly honored to write to you requesting for a loan.

Our company is a leading bakery in Mombasa. We are planning to expand our production capacity from ten thousand loaves a day to one hundred thousand loaves. This will require a lot of money than the company may afford. Because of this, we are inviting you to be part of this project by lending us Ten million shillings repayable in three years.

We are credit worth as you can see from our financial records. You are also welcome to our plant to assess our capability.

I am thanking you in advance as I look forward to your positive reply,

Yours faithfully,

John Juma.

The bakery manager.

## 2. SEMI-BLOCKED LETTERS

MANDASI BORA BAKERY LTD,

P.O Box 2198 Mombasa,

Tel...

27th October 2007.

THE MANAGER, EQUITY BANK MOMBASA,

P.O Box 2849,

Mombasa.

Dear Sir,

**SUBJECT /REF: APPLICATION FOR A LOAN**

I am greatly honored to write to you requesting for a loan.

Our company is a leading bakery in Mombasa. We are planning to expand our production capacity from ten thousand loaves a day to one hundred thousand loaves. This will require a lot

of money than the company may afford. Because of this, we are inviting you to be part of this project by lending us Ten million shillings repayable in three years.

We are credit worth as you can see from our financial records. You are also welcome to our plant to assess our capability.

I am thanking you in advance as I look forward to your positive reply,

Yours faithfully,

John Juma.

The bakery manager.

## UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS

### COURSE: ALL COURSES

#### LESSON 12: FUNCTIONAL WRITING (continuation)

**OBJECTIVES:** At the end of the lesson, the student should be able to understand:

- **Meaning of functional writing**
- **Forms of functional writing**

### Functional writing

Functional writing refers to those texts that we produce in order to achieve a specific purpose.

Pieces of functional writing are intended to fulfill specific needs, like applying for a job, registering to vote, keeping records or publicizing an event.

### Characteristics of functional writing

Although every type of functional writing is unique, there are common features shared by different types of functional writing. They include the following:

1. **Fixed format:** Each type of functional writing has specific parts which are arranged in a fixed order.
2. **Absolute economy:** A piece of functional writing should limit itself exclusively to giving the information required, in the fewest words possible.
3. **Abbreviations:** Several standard abbreviations are allowed in functional writing.

4. **Conventional language:** The language most samples of functional writing does not vary. The expressions used in functional writing are determined by common and regular usage.

## 2.Minutes

Minutes are formal, brief record of the proceedings of a meeting. They are written using a specific format and register.

While writings minutes, you should include the following:

- a) **Title** or heading of the specific meeting, preferably written in capital letters and underlined. Include aspects such as name of the group that is meeting, the date, the venue and the time of meeting.
- b) **Record of attendance:** This will include those present, those absent without apology, those absent with apology and non-member who has been invited to attend (in attendance).
- c) **The preliminaries:** Here you should note the formalities that introduce meeting such as the chair calling the meeting to order, saying a prayer, noting any apologies and the chairperson's welcoming reports.
- d) **Confirmation of the minutes of the previous meeting:** The secretary reads the minutes and one member proposes and then another one seconds. The secretary and the chairperson sign the minutes.
- e) Matters arising from the minutes of the previous meeting, which are discussed in the current meeting.
- f) Business of the day, which is discussed in the current meeting.
- g) **Any other business,** which discusses any other issues not on the agenda.
- h) **Adjournment:** It brings the meeting to a close. The time when the meeting ends is indicated here.
- i) Date for the next meeting, which is mentioned and, preferably, information on venue and time should be given.
- j) Spaces for the chairperson and the secretary to sign after the confirmation of minutes.
- k) Numbering of each item on the agenda as a separate minute.

## 3. MEMO

Memo is short form for memorandum

It is used for internal communication

### FUNCTIONS OF MEMO

#### 1. Conveying information

For better performance, organizational members require information. Memos are the tools to convey information to various internal parties of an organization. This information may be a new policy, new decision, revision of an existing programmed, the appointment of new managers and announcement of special events, like a picnic, excursion schedule etc.

#### 2. Making request

Memo is the medium of making requests for internal parties. Through memos, concerned authority can request someone to attend a meeting to supply information or to perform any function.

#### 3. Providing response

Memo is also used to respond to any request made by memo. Memo conveys the requested information, one's intention, whether to attend a meeting or in a program.

#### 4. Presenting information report

Memo is a helpful tool for presenting informal reports. Informal reports are written in memo form to present facts and recommendations that assist managers in making decisions. Subordinates usually write this [type of memo](#).

#### 5. Solving problems

Memo is also very useful in solving routine and day-to-day operational problems. Memo indicates the ways of performing the job and solving problems. This acts as the guide to action.

### SECTIONS

#### 1. Heading

Memo may or may not have a letter head. This depends on the house customs.

## SAMPLE MEMO

### Internal Memo

To: Departmental heads

From: General Manager

Date: 12th June 2007

### **SUBJECT: FIRST MEETING OF THE YEAR**

This is to inform you that our first meeting for 2007- 2008 financial year will be held on Wednesday 14th June 2007, starting at 9.00 a.m. in the board room.

The Agendas are:

1. Review of the previous years' performance
2. Presentation of departmental budgets
3. A.O.B

Please be punctual

With regards

Peter Omangi

The General Manager

## **4. CURRICULUM VITAE (RESUME)**

It is a record of personal information, educational background, working experience and any other useful information that may help secure employment, scholarship or admission to an institution of learning.

While writing a CV, include the following:

- a) **Personal information:** name, date of birth, nationality, postal address, telephone/mobile phone contact and email address.
- b) **Career objective:** Captures your professional goal and division
- c) **Educational background:** academic qualification starting with the latest to the earliest.
- d) **Skills:** practical abilities such as typing and driving skills.
- e) **Achievements:** Any special awards you may have received.

- f) **Hobbies and interests:** Activities you are involved in during your free time.
- g) **References:** People who can be contacted to say a thing or two about you.

## **4. PUBLIC NOTICE**

These are notices that give specific information meant for consumption by the general public. The messages contained in public notices are short and to the point. They should indicate the event, time and venue.

### **EXAMPLE**

#### **KICK POLIO OUT OF KENYA**

**Polio is an infectious disease that can cause permanent paralysis. You can stop it with a simple vaccine. Bring your child aged five years and below for vaccination.**

**WHERE: TABIBU HEALTH CLINIC**

**DATE: 14 TO 20<sup>TH</sup> JULY 2018**

**TIME: 8:00 AM to 5:00PM**

**THIS SERVICE IS FREE!**

**LET'S JOIN HANDS TO KICK POLIO OUT OF KENYA.**

**(Courtesy of: test it and fix it revised edition)**

## **5. POSTER**

It is a large notice put in a public place to communicate some information. Most posters have pictures and brief catchy messages. To make a poster more captivating, one can use bright and attractive colours. Common types of posters include election posters, those giving public information like free medical checkups, those advertising goods and services and those communicating important information from local administrative authorities.

### **EXAMPLE**

**EMMANUEL MATARA**

**A man of vision and mission**

**INVITES ALL TO:**

**Young Entrepreneurs Summit**

**Venue: Tom Mboya Social Hall**

**Date: 17 August 2018**

Time: 9:30 a.m-3:30 p.m.

Entrance: KSH 299 ONLY

## **EQUIPPING TOMMORROWS GENERATION**

### **6. SPEECH**

It is simply a spoken essay. You should, therefore, observe the rules of essay writing as you write the speech but in the final analysis it will be presented orally.

When writing a speech, you need to observe the following:

- a) Make the speech brief and to the point
- b) Make your introduction simple and clearly outline the points you will make in speech.
- c) Use memory devices, for example repetition, to keep reminding the audience of the main points.
- d) Address the audience correctly.
- e) Use simple concrete language –do not use abstract words.
- f) Make each of your points short in clearly developed paragraphs
- g) Relate your writing personally to yourself and to your audience.

### **7. INVITATION**

We write invitations to ask our acquaintances for their presence or contributions during particular functions or events such as weddings, fundraising ceremonies or graduation parties.

Most invitations are in the form of letters but in some cases they are printed cards. An invitation should have the following information:

- a) Address of the writer
- b) Salutation
- c) Type of function and if necessary, mode of dressing
- d) Date, time and venue of the function
- e) Sign-off
- f) A map to the venue of the function

The tone and choice of words in an invitation should urge the recipient to accept the invitation.

### **8. ELECTRONIC MAIL (E MAIL)**

This is a way of sending messages and data to other people by means of computers connected together in a network. Emails are easy, fast and cheaper to use than other conventional methods of communicating .The structure of an email is a follows:

- a) From: This identifies the sender
- b) Date: This is the date when the mail was sent
- c) To: This is the address of the receiver
- d) Cc: This is the address of the person who will receive a copy of the email.
- e) Subject: This is the main message that the sender wants to convey

A good email should:

- a) Not be too short to communicate
- b) Not use slang and short messages

## **Example of an Email:**

FROM:wshiro@hotmail.com

TO:mkoko3@yahoo.com

Cc:Zabanene@gmail.com

## **SUBJECT: Visit Cancellation**

I am sorry that I will not visit you this coming Sunday as we had agreed earlier on. Nzambanene, our friend, has invited me for a literature set books symposium at their school on the same day.

He however has promised you that we will visit you next Sunday.

**(COURTESY: TEST IT AND FIX IT REVISED EDITION)**

## **9. INSTRUCTIONS TO FAMILY AND FRIENDS**

Instructions to family and friends should be simple and clear so that those receiving the instructions will understand them. The following points are important when we give a set of written instructions:

- a) They should be introduced by simple requests ,for example: *Please do the following*
- b) They should be in the imperative
- c) They should be numbered
- d) They should be short and precise

## **EXAMPLE:**

**Hi Tanisha,**

I have left for the scouts' camp. Please do the following before mum comes back from the market.

- Hang the clothes in the green basin on the clothes line

- Take the cows to the new paddock
- Sweep the main house and empty the trash can

Ouma.

## k **SHORT MESSAGE SERVICE(SMS)**

This is a way in which text messages can be sent via a mobile phone. It is an effective way of communicating not only because it is fast but it is also cheap. They are usually brief and to the point.

People also tend to shorten words by omitting or substituting vowels and constants. The shortening of words should, however, not make the recipient struggle so much to decipher the intended meaning.

## l **FORM**

It is a document that contains questions with spaces provided to fill in the answers. Filling in forms requires accuracy. Use legible handwriting. You are also advised to use capital letters. e.g application form for scholarship, learning institution etc.

## m **LETTER OF APOLOGY**

An apology letter is written to a person you have wronged, hurt or offended to show that you are sorry for your actions.

An apology letter should be forthright. A lot of explanation will be interpreted as an attempt to absolve oneself from any wrongdoing and blame. The opening sentence of a good apology letter should carry the acceptance of blame and the apology itself. Most apology letters are formal because of the seriousness of the message they carry.

## n **DIARY**

It is a daily record of things to be done on specific days and at specific times. Most people keep a diary because it helps them organize their time efficiently. A diary should tell the date, day and time of an event, meeting or activity.

## 15. **SHOPPING LIST**

A shopping list shows the items we intend to buy, their quantities and approximate prices. Writing a shopping list helps one to buy the item they really need and budget efficiently. It also helps one to approximate the total amount of money he/she needs for shopping.

A good shopping list should have a title, items quantity and approximate price per item.

## 16. **RECIPE**

It is a set of instructions on how to prepare or cook some food .Such instructions include the ingredients to be used and their measurements and the method of cooking.

For cake and some food, the recipe also indicates the temperature at which the food should be prepared and for how long. Recipes are written using active verbs and the instructions should be clear and concise.

**REFERENCE: (COURTSEY: TEST IT AND FIX IT REVISED EDITION)**

**Question: Write a recipe for your favorite meal**

**UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

**COURSE: ALL COURSES**

**LESSON 13: SUMMARY WRITING**

**OBJECTIVES: At the end of the lesson the student should be able to:**

- **Learn the meaning of summary writing**
- **Understand the importance of summarizing passages/information**
- **Understand more about report writing**

## **SUMMARY WRITING**

Summary is also referred to as precise or abstract. It means a prose passage or composition from which all unnecessary and unrelated ideas and words have been removed.

Its summary constructed by extracting the key sentences or a paragraph and putting them together coherently

Word precise is a French term that means exact or just. A precise is written in precise writer own words and about  $\frac{1}{3}$  of original passage.

## **Objectives of Precise/Summary**

Objective of summary is to put down in short form a message which can be understood by very busy officers who do not have time to read original passage.

## **Qualities of good summary**

i) Should be concise

I.e. a summary should be as long or short to serve the purpose.

ii) Clarity

– It has to be clear.

iii) Coherent

I.e. it should hold together. You can use the following words to join sentences or paragraphs consequently. Moreover, however, naturally, next, thus, nevertheless, finally etc. You can also use phrases to join paragraphs or sentences e.g. equally important, in this way, on contrary, first of all, on the other hand, of course, for instance etc.

## **How to make summary**

1. Read the passage thoroughly. Try to get general idea of passage
2. Read the passage again until you have grasped the entire meaning
3. Underline/highlight all important ideas.
4. Write down a title which sums up the theme of the passage
5. Rewrite in fewer words what the author has said, use your own language as far as possible.
6. Re-read the passage, compare you point with passage to ensure no important points have been overlooked and nothing insignificant has been included.
7. Using your points write down sum and substance of the passage in well-connected and readable paragraphs. This is your rough draft.
8. Count the words in your rough draft. Make alterations if necessary to give your summary the required length.
9. Review and rephrase you rough draft where desirable.
10. Reconsider the appropriateness of your heading/title.

## **Title/ Heading**

The heading can be written before the summary is made. The heading should express in few words the theme of passage.

The topic should be written one line or less. More than one line may appear confusing. A summary can have many suitable headings but you should choose the best that gives the central theme or the passage.

## **Rules of writing summary**

- i. Determine the theme of passage very carefully.
- ii. A summary is not reproduction of important sentences but it's the act of remodeling.
- iii. Brevity is good but not at the expense of clarity.
- iv. Your summary ought to be intelligible even to persons who have not read the original passage.
- v. Use your own language.
- vi. Summary is always written in 3rd Person.
- vii. Use your own discretion if the passage contains statistical information.
- viii. The summary should be well proportioned.
- ix. You are not to give any comments appreciative or critical on ideas expressed in the passage.
- x. Reproduce the passage to its 1/3rd.

## **How to achieve brevity**

1. Try to replace clauses by phrases and phrases by words. E.g. "an arrangement of a permanent nature," Can be written as "A permanent arrangement"

E.g. "To a considerable degree" you can write "considerably".

2. Make use of one word substitutions. E.g. "the secretary's proposal was adopted with the full agreement of all the members". You can simply say "the secretary's proposal was adopted unanimously".

3. Avoid unnecessary repetition e.g. it was decided to allow only our own executives to participate in the seminar and not to invite any external participants. The words in italics are unnecessary repetitions.

4. it's important to link various sentences. For example; we are selling a new garden fertilizer in the market. It's in form of powder. Its colour is pink. You can dust it on the plants. You can dissolve it in water and spray. You can say "Our new garden fertilizer, a fine pink colored powder can be dusted on the plants or dissolved in water and sprayed".

5. When writing a summary; omit examples, comparisons, contrasts and mere details

## REPORTS

A report is an orderly presentation of facts about specific business activities or programs. Reports can also be defined as a communication from someone who has some information to someone who wants to use that information.

It's a document in which a given problem is examined for the purpose of conveying information, reporting, finding, putting forward, ideas and sometimes making recommendations.

### Business report

It's a document which investigates a specific subject according to a prescribed format and for a clearly defined leadership. A report can be oral or written. However, a written report is preferred to an oral report for a number of reasons:

1. Oral report can be denied at any time but written report is a permanent report and it cannot be denied.
2. An oral report tends to be vague. It may contain some irrelevant facts and some important points may be overlooked.
3. A written report tends to be accurate and precise.
4. A written report can be referred to again and again.
  - Report can be either informative or interpretative.

### Informative reports

An Informative report is one that represents facts pertinent to a given situation or issue.

### Interpretive reports

They are reports that analyze the facts, draw conclusion and make recommendations .e.g. An informative report on sale of tables, draws will simply record the number of tables sold during a given month/months.

An interpretive report on sale of tables, we analyze why and to what extent the sale of tables go up during summer month i.e. May-July and it will make recommendation on the schedule of production.

## **Importance of reports**

Report is basic management tool that is used for decision making

## **Characteristics of reports**

- It should be precise, clear and answering the questions that is being investigated.
- A report should have accurate facts because they are used for decision making inaccurate facts may lead to disastrous decisions.
- A report must be relevant i.e. should contain only relevant facts. Irrelevant facts should not appear in the report.
- A good report should be leader oriented.
- Objectivity of recommendation. If you are to write conclusions make sure they are impartial and they are objective. They should come as logical conclusions to investigation and analysis.
- Reports should be written in simple and ambiguous language.
- Report should be clear and brief.
- A report should be grammatically correct.
- A report should be characterized by clear expression and neat display. It should be nature of agreement well-reasoned and arranged, accurate in all details and leading logically to the conclusions and recommendations set forth.

## **Types of business reports**

1. Based on legal formulations reports are of two kinds

### **(a) Formal Reports**

They are prepared in prescribed form and presented accordingly to an established procedure to prescribed authority.

### **(b) Informal Reports**

Usually inform of person to person communication and usually submitted in form of letter or memo.

Formal reports can be divided into two:-

- (a) **Statutory reports** – They are prepared and presented according to the form and procedure laid down by law. E.g. the directors of a company are required to submit a statutory report to the shareholders in annual general meeting.

(i) An auditor's report

**(b) Non statutory reports**

Are formal reports which are not required under any law? E.g. management may require a departmental head to write a report on a certain issue.

2. Based on number of persons writing a report

(a) Report by individuals

(b) Report by committee or sub committee

3 On the basis of nature of reports

(a) Periodic or routine reports

(b) Progress reports

(c) Examination reports

(d) Recommendation reports

(e) Statistical reports

## **Writing a Report**

1. Before beginning you need to know why you are writing the report and what exactly you are writing about.

2. You need to keep report accurate and relevant

3. While writing the report omit opinions from sections concerning the facts.

4. Organize your points in a logical order.

5. Use your judgment and experience when suggesting actions or making recommendations.

6. Use language suited to the leader and make sure each section has clear heading.

## **Sections of a Report**

### **1. The title**

The title should be concise but comprehensive. The situation stated briefly together with name of company and date of the event. E.g. Report on staffing levels in the general office engineering on Friday 15th December 2006.

### **2. Background**

This contains two kinds of information. Brief descriptions of circumstances under discussion and outline of the procedure/method of inquiry used by writer. E.g. On Friday 15th December the general office was staffed only by Mr. Jones and the other four staff members were absent. As a result the services available were limited. I have discussed the matter in confidence with each member of staff involved and also with other departments which were concerned.

### **3. Findings**

This is the part of report. It presents in simple clear, unbiased terms an account of the events or circumstances which form the subject of the report.

#### **Principles to follow when preparing the findings**

1. Organize your material in sections according to subject area and present each one under a clear descriptive heading which could be clearly numbered.
2. Write in clear, single style points under consideration only. Don't note from or numbered from below your findings.
3. Include only those statistics that are really essential to support your points.

The findings do not interpret, they only give the observations

### **4. Conclusions**

This means that section of report that interprets the facts and the observations represented in the findings. It presents direct and clear interpretation of event or circumstances.

#### **Basic Principles of presenting conclusions**

1. Conclusions should be presented under the same series of subject heading as findings and in the same order with the same system of numbering.
2. It should be written in simple continuous prose.
3. Do not include statistics or graphs or maps which have not been included in the findings.

### **5. Recommendations**

It's the final section of a report and it puts forward future course of action concerning the topic under investigation.

#### **Principles of presenting recommendations**

1. Each recommendation should be as specific as possible given the information available.

2. Even when we feel the present arrangement for a certain aspect of topic is satisfactory, you should mention this in the recommendation section. E.g. current arrangement for replacing lost library tickets is satisfactory and should remain unchanged.

3. Recommendations should be grouped under the same heading and should appear in the same order as used in findings or conclusions.

4. Recommendations must rest on the information and the findings and the reasoning in conclusions so that the leader can see that the reports proceed clearly and logically and nothing has been cancelled.

5. Signature, Name, Position and date.

This should follow each other in that sequence.

**QUESTION: Kassim Owango has been working under you as an accountant for the last six years in Imara Commercial Agencies. He has been offered a job as a manager in Bora Bora Bank and the Chief Financial Officer in the bank wishes to know about his professional conduct from you. Write the confidential report you will send to the chief financial officer.**

## **UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

### **COURSE: ALL COURSES**

#### **LESSON 14: READING**

**OBJECTIVES: At the end of the lesson the student should be able to:**

- Understand the meaning of word reading
- Learn the reading techniques
- Familiarize themselves with kinds of listeners
- Understand the bad listening habits
- Understand how you can contribute to effective listening

## **READING**

Many readers waste a lot of time for two reasons:

(i) They read everything at the same speed, often at a slow pace.

(ii) They do not understand or retain what they have read

A good reader adjusts his/her speed according to the purpose or difficulty of the subject-matter.

## **READING TECHNIQUES**

### **1) Scanning**

It's the process of looking quickly through a text to find a particular piece of information.

To scan move your eyes quickly down the text looking for key words related to the topic in question. Scanning is used for reading street or telephone directories to find particular name.

It's also used when you need to go through a piece of continuous writing to find specific piece of information e.g. Statistics.

Scanning can be useful for reading annual report, catalogue. Members of staff read many reports. Scanning is important to allow them graze the main draft of the report.

### **How to increase scanning speed**

Draw a finger down the center of the page while moving your eyes rapidly from side to side as you follow it down.

Uses of certain techniques – move an envelope or piece of paper down the page curtaining off the line you have read.

### **2) Skimming**

Skimming is glancing at speed over the printed words on a page.

In skimming words are not individually noted but an impression is gained.

Skimming requires a lot of concentration to get an idea of what the text is all about.

### **Where skimming is used**

I. To preview

II. To identify priorities where to read more slowly.

III. To find a required piece of information

IV. To help memory by immediate grasp of what we have just read.

### **How to skim**

a) **Anticipation.**

As we read we should aim to understand the whole content by seeing the complete picture rather than the small separate bits. This means that you think faster than you read and make predictions or what you expect to read next. E.g. if a problem has been described, you may well anticipate a solution.

## **(b) Organization**

Go through the structure or patterns of the writing. This skeleton will help you in grasping the whole text e.g. a book is divided into chapters and subsections.

If we go through the structure we find our way more speedily.

## **Study Reading**

This is required when you need to read in detail, when studying a report or a textbook study reading is crucial mostly when reading contracts and other legal documents.

## **Method**

1. When you take a textbook, make sure of all the clues it offers before you actually begin to read it.
2. Read the 'blurb' inspect the context page I read the preface and check the subject index.
3. While reading, look for the internal skeleton for synopsis and summarize for topic sentences in paragraphs, for headings and italics which may emphasize key points by making the book and taking notes.
4. Skim the notes once you have finished reading.

## **LISTENING**

Listening is a very important aid to communication. Listening is not the same as hearing.

Hearing is an automatic reaction of the senses and nervous system. Listening is hard and requires effort. You have to choose to listen or not to.

## **Kinds of Listeners**

### **i) Passive Listeners**

Do not pay attention to what is being said they pay more attention to the persons speaking.

### **ii) Active Listeners**

Guide the speaker towards a common interest. Listening is the most important skill in management.

## **IMPORTANCE**

## **Advantages of Listening**

- ii) Listening helps you keep things in perspective.
- iii) Listening is critical for success in family life and among friends
- iv) Good listening will help you do well in school
- v) It will help you to know the relationships at work.
- vi) Listening helps to know the organization, especially to grapevine will help you to know what the members of staff think of the Co. policies and activities.
- vii) Listening helps to make better policies. You listen to subordinates carefully. You will know which policies are suitable for your organization.
- viii) Listening mollifies complaining patients and sympathetically, their anger will subside and they will leave mollified.
- ix) Listening helps to spot sensitive areas before they become explosive.
- x) Listening is important for the open-door policy. If managers listen then the open-door policy will make meaning.

## **WAYS TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING**

- i) Know when to listen. Intensity of listening should vary throughout the session.
- ii) Concentrate on what a person is saying rather than on how he looks.
- iii) Repeat the key ideas to yourself particularly while listening to a long lecture.
- iv) Try to relate the speaker's remarks to your personal background and experience.
- v) Do not let your mind wander away from what the speaker is saying. Do not think of the pleasant or unpleasant experiences of your own.
- vi) Listen with a positive attitude. Many listeners fail to listen because they are mentally unprepared to listen.

## **Listening 'Spare time' How to use it to your advantage.**

Stray thoughts may take you away from the speaker's briefs, so you keep jumping out and jumping back, these excursions away from the speaker are dangerous.

During such times try to do the following:

- a) Explore

Try to anticipate what the speaker will say next – you are likely to understand the next point more.

## b) Analyze

Analyze the speaker's message as he makes arguments and defends assertions;

## c) Review

When a speaker pauses try to review what he/she has just said. This will help you remember & understand.

## d) Search for hidden meanings.

Listen between the lines for hidden meaning as the speaker progresses.

E – Explore

A – Analyze

R – Review

S – Search for hidden meanings

## **Bad Listening habits**

### i) Turning out dull topics

Some listeners decide early on that a topic is not interesting, these decision leads to lack of attention and concentration.

### ii) Faking Attention

We pretend to pay attention to listeners who fake attention look like they will wake up with a jerk of the head and a dazed look good listeners lean forward with interest and good eye contact and react in a natural way with smiles nods & questioning looks.

### iii) Yielding to distractions

Peripheral noises or movements often affect our concentration a sneeze or a fall of a book may cause distraction. Avoid yielding to such distractions.

### iv) Criticizing delivery or physical appearance.

A listener may abandon their good listening habits by being overly critical of the speaker's physical appearance or delivery.

### v) Jumping to conclusions

Try to be patient even if you think you know what the other person is going to say. Many listeners are quick to judge before they have carefully heard what the speaker meant.

### vi) Overreacting to emotional words

If a speaker says a great point, you might experience a strong emotional reaction. This may block your ability to listen.

vii) Interrupting

Many people more of what they are going to say than what is being said.

## **Contributions listeners make:**

- Process of listening involves paying attention organizing what you hear and remembering for both the short term and the long term.

- Listeners may add a vital element to communication feedback by listening responsively; you tell the speaker how to behave such as; to continue talking, back-up, to slow down, repeat, explain or stop.

- It is the responsibility of the listener to show the speaker what you think.

## **How to contribute to listening**

### **i) Providing encouragement.**

Silence may be soothing at times among close friends but to most speakers it means boredom. You can add 'uh – huh' or oh? Or I see"

### **ii) Asking for Explanations.**

When you ask questions you help the speaker make his message more understandable. You may ask 'would you please clarify that?' "Would you say that again?" – "I don't understand what you mean?"

### **iii) Paraphrasing the message:**

You repeating in your own words e.g. what I hear you saying is -----

In other words your view is -----etc.

### **iv) Summarizing the message**

You condense the important points into a brief comment e.g. "What you have said so far is ....."

Your key ideas as I understand it, are....."

### **v) Putting it down on paper.**

Taking notes automatically improves our attentiveness. It helps you focus on the highlights of what is being said.

## **FIVE WAYS TO LISTEN:**

### **a) Appreciate Listening:**

We listen appreciatively when we enjoy music

A bird's song or the murmur of a brook (river)

### **b) Discriminative listening**

When we want to single out one particular sound from a noisy environment e.g. when listening for a friend's voice in a crowded room.

### **iii) Comprehensive listening**

When we want to understand. When we listen to directions or instructions we use comprehensive listening.

### **iv) Therapeutic Listening**

The style practiced by counselors psychiatrists and good friends, encourages people to talk freely without fear embarrassment. Friends act as our sounding boards. When we just want someone to listen.

The therapeutic listener in conversation with a troubled friend accepts what is said and tries hard to understand and above all makes no judgments.

### **v) Critical Listening**

These are the most active of all listeners.

Try hard to decide whether what someone else says makes sense.

Critical listeners evaluate what they hear and decide if another person's

Message is logical, worthwhile, or has value.

## **UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

### **COURSE: ALL COURSES**

### **LESSON 15: SPEECHES**

## **OBJECTIVES: To be able to:**

- Understand the different characteristics of a speech

- Learn the profile of a good speaker

Understand the preparation of a good speech

- argue appropriately in a communication process

- use persuasion to achieve given results

## **1 SPEECHES**

Speech or spoken word is very powerful, it can stir people to mutinies (violent commotion) and rebellions or it can turn a hostile crowd to a friendly gathering.

The key to the success of many politicians, industrialists, managers, and salesmen lies in their ability to speak.

### **CHARACTERISTICS OF A GOOD SPEECH**

1. It is clear.

Your speech should convey to the audience the ideas, emotions, facts or arguments you want to express.

2. It is like an informal talk

When you speak there should be a perfect rapport between you and your audience.

3. It is vivid and concrete

Use concrete facts that are easy to comprehend and visualize. Instead of saying the population of India is growing very fast, a speaker said see how fast our population grows one Australia is added the population of India every year and Australia's area is two and half times that of India.

4. It is brief

An audience can last up to twenty minutes. Your speech should be tailored to that length. To achieve brevity, include only a few points and elaborate at length

5. It is interesting

Quotations, anecdotes and humorous touches often make a speech interesting. Quotations should be from acceptable authorities. They should be familiar but not worn out. Anecdotes should be new brief and in good taste. Humor should be topical, original spontaneous and gentle.

6. It is audience oriented

A good speech should be tailored to the wavelength of the audience. Consider the following points:

- i) Is the audience general or specializes one? This will help you determine the depth of the subject
- ii) How large is the audience? For a small audience the speech will be more like a chat in a large gathering you will have to be rhetorical.
- iii) What is the age group of the listeners? Your reference and illustrations should conform to the tastes of that particular group.
- iv) What is the social religious political and economic views and prejudice of the listeners? What is the expected audience response?

## **PROFILE OF A GOOD SPEAKER**

1. "A good speaker is lively, interested enthusiastic and vital."

He treats his audience as a group of living people. He is keenly interested in the subject he is speaking about and takes pain to make the audience equally interested in it.

2. "A good speaker is earnest". He does not speak just for the sake of speaking – in order to show off, to impress the audience with his erudition or his authority.

3. "A good speaker has a sense of responsibility to others on the program". He does not take more time than what is allotted to him.

4. "A good speaker has a sense of responsibility to his subject". He does not bite more than he can chew. He does not spread it thin.

5. "A good speaker has a sense of leadership; he stands up tall, he talks eye to eye, he speaks responsibly and with authority as a leader should"

6. "A good speaker is not get carried off by his over- enthusiasm or over-confidence.

7. "A good speaker tries to be balanced and sane"

8. "A good speaker keeps his sense of humor"

## **PREPARATION FOR A SPEECH**

1. Research your topic thoroughly. Identify the points for discussion and decide what you have to say about them.
2. Plan your speech in three parts;
  - i) The beginning should arouse the interest of the audience.
  - ii) The middle should be devoted to discussion
  - lii) The conclusion should summarize the main points, and if some action is to be taken it clearly tells the audience what they are required.
3. Time your speech to make sure it is neither too long nor too short.
4. Look for some suitable quotations or anecdotes if possible.
5. Arrange your points in such a way that strong points are kept at the beginning.
6. Tailor your speech to the intellectual level and general taste of the audience.
7. Make sure that your delivery is going to be good, rehearse the speech use a tape recorder or video recorder to fine tune your tone and mannerism.

## **PERSUADING SPEECH**

Purpose of speech to persuade is to change, Create or reinforce attitudes or behavior.

Persuasion is the process of changing listener's beliefs or moving a listener to action.

Persuasion is also a form of influence; it's the process or guiding people towards the adoption of an idea attitude or action by rational and symbolic means.

It's a strategy of problem solving relying on appeals rather than force.

### **Techniques of persuasion**

- ***Thinking***

To be our effective persuasive speaker, you need to develop a number of different types of thinking skills related to making judgment and decision. They include:

- (a) Perceiving – Ability to listen and observe to compare and contrast your observation so as to organize and interpret them to understand how you own point of view influences your perceptions.
- (b) Arranging – Your ability to group your perceptions classify them discover pattern in them and place them in order of importance.
- (c) Enquiring – Your ability to ask questions about and analyze meaning of your perceptions.

(d) It refers to your ability to recognize, underlying assumptions to make generalizations to understand cause effect relationship and make predictions.

(e) Reasoning – your ability to make decisions and arrive at judgment.

- ***Using appeals to logic***

Start by clarifying the specific purpose of the speech. This is position of your speech. Support your speech with logical argument.

The arguments should rely an objective information instead of personal preference or opinions. Each logical argument must be supported by evidence, factual examples, statistics, exports, testimony or other specific details about the argument logical arguments are made using:

(i) Inductive reasoning

We begin particular facts and proceeds to larger general conclusions based on these facts. E.g. if we taste a number of hard greed apples and find that they are sour, we are likely to conclude that apples are green and are also sour.

(ii) Deductive reasoning

We begin with general statement know to be accepted as true and proceed to particular facts that logically follow form these general statements e.g. All citizens have the right to vote women are citizens, they have the right to vote. Make general statement is true, then make sure the 2nd part fits into the generalization made by 1st statement.

Preparing a persuasive speech based on logical appeals.

i) Select a topic narrow enough to be covered within allotted time.

ii) Find out what positions people hold in this topic.

iii) Research the arguments supporting and opposing each position.

iv) Decide on your position and write it as a thesis statement.

v) Analyze your audience, its background interests and prejudices.

vi) Complete your research using a variety of reliable resources.

vii) Decide which arguments and what kinds of supporting evidence will be most effective with your audience.

viii) Outline the main arguments of your speech and evidence you will use to support each argument.

ix) Outline the arguments and evidence you will use to counter position others may take.

x) Decide what visual aid will make your speech more effective.

- xi) Prepare introduction and conclusion of your speech.
- xii) Prepare notes for your speech and practice it alone.
- xiii) Practice your speech before at least one other person, ask the person for his response.
- xiv) Revise your speech in accordance with the person's response.

### ***3. Using Appeals to Emotion***

Use your body language to emphasize appeals to listener's emotions.

Emotional appeals are based on.

#### ***(i) Physical needs***

Involve the life and health of individual's body e.g. need for food and need for physical pain.

#### ***(ii) Psychological needs***

Involves an individual's inner life e.g. need for love and need for self-respect.

#### ***(iii) Social needs***

Involves an individual relationship with a group e.g. need for freedom, need for status and power and need for acceptance by others.

You need to consider your specific purposes and you want to be certain that each appeal you choose will lead your listeners to accept the position stated by your thesis rather than formulate arguments against it.

You need to know your audience most important needs, their interests and fears.

If you misjudge your audience, your appeals to their emotions will not be persuasive then use a contest and statement that appeal to specific emotions and that will sway your listeners in favor of your position.

Use vivid language and a more intense tone of voice and gestures.

Avoid unfair and dishonest persuasive techniques such as telling lies or half-truths, calling names, using absentees and making irrelevant personal attacks. All these will be

### ***4. Using identification***

When you give a persuasive speech you should encourage your listeners to regard it as a person who can be trusted and believed.

You will want them to belief that you are a person like them, at other times you will want them to know that you are an expert in the topic whose knowledge will benefit them.

Ethical appeal (ethics is an appeal to an audience to identify with and trust the speaker)

## **Guidelines to identification with the audience**

### **i) Establish your own credibility**

At the opening part of your speech is on need to make it clear that you have been well informed about the topic e.g. what you have done to establish your expertise or you simply let your words talk on your behalf.

### **(ii) Evoke the good will of your listeners**

Persuade them that you share common interests with them and that you are sincerely committed to those interests. You can also evoke goodwill by complimenting the audience on its positive varieties and by identifying with a person the audience admires.

### **(iii) Speak with genuine self-confidence and enthusiasm**

Your voice, posture, gestures and other non-verbal areas communicate your enthusiasm as much as your words do.

## ***5. Using identification with appeals to logic and appeals to emotion.***

To use the 3 combined you need to keep the following points in mind.

Be sure each logical argument directly supports your thesis and will be understandably by convincing to your audience.

(ii) Use appeals to emotion in presenting main points based on basic human, physical, psychological or social needs.

Be sure each appeal to emotion directly supports your position and will be understandable by and convincing to your audience.

Use specific techniques that will encourage your audience to identify with you.

Consider how you can appear best credible and self-confident and how you can best evoke your listener's goodwill.

If you establish their identification with you at an early stage, your listeners will be particularly willing to be persuaded by the speech.

## **QUESTION:**

**"Fear of Public speaking is believed to be the most common phobia in the world". As a presenter of the above mentioned talk. Explain the methods you will apply to overcome this fear (10 Marks)**

**UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

**COURSE: ALL COURSES**

**LESSON 16: MEETINGS**

**OBJECTIVES:** At the end of the lesson, the student should:

- Understand the meaning of terms minutes and meeting
- Understand the steps involved in record meeting minutes
- Learn role of meetings and minutes in organizations
- Understand the different types of meetings
- Learn the different types of minutes
- Learn what discussion is
- Understand the different types of discussions

**Meeting:** a planned occasion when people come together to discuss something (Cambridge dictionary).

It also refers to a meeting is when two or more people come together to discuss one or more topics, often in a formal or business setting, but meetings also occur in a variety of other environments

It can also refer to a situation when two or more people meet, by chance or arrangement.

**Minutes:** Meeting minutes are notes that are recorded during a meeting. They highlight the key issues that are discussed, motions proposed or voted on, and activities to be undertaken. The minutes of a meeting are usually taken by a designated member of the group. Their task is to provide an accurate record of what transpired during the meeting. They're also a record of which individuals made contributions to the meeting in terms of new ideas and how those ideas were received.

### **Steps Involved in Recording Meeting Minutes**

There are five main steps involved in recording the minutes of a meeting. They are:

- Pre-planning
- Record-taking
- Writing or transcribing the minutes
- Sharing meeting minutes

- Filing or storage of minutes for referencing in the future

## **ROLE OF MEETINGS AND MINUTES IN ORGANIZATIONS**

### **It serves as a reminder**

With so many things going on at once, forgetting a thing or two is unavoidable, but the team can depend on the minutes to check on their progress. Are they on target? Is there anything missing? What else is left to do? You won't overlook any task as long as you have a precise document that can help you remember anything and everything.

### **It will serve as a reference for members who weren't present during the meeting**

Conflicts in schedule or emergencies may happen and some individuals won't make it to the meeting. By creating meeting summaries, everyone who missed the meeting can be updated on what happened and be informed on what they missed. Hence, no one is left hanging and every person is on the same page on what the goals of the company are and how to reach them.

### **Meeting minutes offer legal protection**

Minutes are important details that you can't ignore if you want to keep your business in line with state laws, and to back up your tax returns. Minutes represent the actions of the Board and company leadership, and are considered legal documents by auditors, the IRS, and the courts. Legal experts will maintain that if an action isn't in the minutes, it didn't happen.

### **It becomes your guide**

By taking note of the meeting, you and your team can keep tabs of the commitments and when they are due. The meeting minutes could serve as a map where all the plans are laid out in front of you, and you'll have a guide as you accomplish each and every action item.

## **TYPES OF MEETINGS**

### **1. Sales conference meetings**

A sales conference is one of the most common types of meetings in a company with significant number sales agents. As we all know, most sales representatives spend much of their time working alone, often off the office. Holding this type of meetings on a regular basis forms an excellent motivational and communication tool that brings them together with other company's employees. During these meetings, sales managers can launch important initiatives like a major advertising campaign, the announcement of a new product, and even communicating organization's sales plans for the subsequent financial year(s).

## **2. Staff meeting**

The staff meeting is another common type of meetings in a work environment. The managers and supervisors call it, and its objective is to keep workers informed on the current issues affecting them on their work as well as those affecting their department(s). If there is a significant issue or policy change that affects the entire organization, the staff meeting is the right forum to unveil the information and explain the change to employees. Appraisal meeting is a form of the staff meeting where supervisors and managers hold one-on-one meetings with workers to review their work performance vis-à-vis targets that constitute the basis of salary review and assessment of individual training needs.

## **3. Information sharing meetings**

Information sharing meetings are one of the most important types of meeting in business communication. As the name suggests, it is all about informing participants about a particular issue or rather sharing crucial information. In most cases, this type of meeting is often educational, such as panel debates and seminars. To hold successful information sharing meeting, meeting planners need to keep participants engaged. The primary challenge with this kind of meeting arises when organizers invite outside speakers, who in most cases, have a hard time trying to ensure the information shared is personalized to the organization. Nonetheless, in the next meeting, attendees should be asked to provide speakers with some feedback about the previous session. That way, information sharing session becomes active and efficient!

## **4. Innovation meetings**

The innovation meetings can be considered as one of the types of private meetings that often begin with thinking outside the box, by associating, brainstorming, and more importantly, sharing ideas in a wider scope. Innovation is considered to be the primary key to success for every organization, and this explains this type of meeting is held quite often. For innovation meetings to be productive, three things ought to be done right, and it is taking notes, following through, and full participation. Those attending the meeting can use several processes and techniques to express their ideas to come up with focused suggestions. Through evaluations, decision making, and ranking, the most suitable ideas and tasks are identified and recommendations stated for further action by the company management.

## **5. Team building meetings**

Team building meetings are among the common 5 different types of formal meetings often held in a workplace. Despite the fact that all kinds of meeting discussed earlier should contribute to corporate culture, strengthening the relationship, and team building, there are specific meeting designed to focus specifically on team building activities. This category includes meetings such as kick-off meetings, all-hands meetings, corporate events, and team building outings. It is necessary for managers and supervisors to note that having their participants feel

like critical parts of their team, unit, branch, department, and company as a whole has a positive impact on worker's performance, satisfaction, and of course, on performance.

## **Conclusion**

There are endless types of workplace meetings, and those explained above are just some of the most common. While most of these quite distinctive, being aware of the specific features of a particular meeting will help you better identify the structure, goals, and activities appropriate for your meetings. Since workplace meetings represent an immense value to both the employees and the organization, earning a reputation for planning and running a fruitful and efficient meeting will depend entirely on knowing the different types of meeting.

Meetings are held to discuss particular issues or matters. For the meetings to be successful the following should be done.

- i) Define the purpose of the meeting clearly
- ii) Distribute the agenda among all members.
- iii) Provide all the facts e.g. you may distribute a copy of previous year results and some comments to the members.
- (iv) Restrict the number of invitees

## **TYPES OF MINUTES**

- **Agenda-based minutes**

These are a traditional type of record: minutes taken at scheduled meetings for which there is an agenda. An agenda is either distributed before the meeting or announced by the chairperson at the beginning, and the minutes follow the framework set by the agenda. At

- **Informal meeting minutes**

Most departmental and team meetings do not require detailed minutes. Informal meeting minutes summarize decisions taken and follow-up actions and responsibilities. Typically, these minutes are circulated to all those who attended the meeting, and sometimes to others who have an interest in the meeting's decisions but were not able to attend. These records are sometimes produced using a simple template.

**To be successful as a chairman observe the following:-**

1. Punctuality
2. Clearly define the purpose of the meeting
3. Begin with a positive approach and don't start on negatives.

4. Your opening remarks should be brief. Short openings suggest the urgency of problem.
5. Sight out the initial silence. After the opening remarks there's silence because of members general reluctance to speak. Some people may be thinking about the probability and others not want to speak. The chairman should assist members to open up.
6. Remain impartial sometimes conflicts and personality shake ups may arise. The chairman should be able to control the situation. He should not take sides.
7. Control emotional build ups sometimes during the discussion emotions and tensions may build up. The chairman should use humour to control tempers.
8. Draw contributions from all members.
9. Control the meeting
10. Creatively control opposing points of view.
11. Clarify contributions
12. Make frequent summarize of progress of the meeting to all parent.
13. Point out the decisions reached.
14. Point out differences.
15. Point out the course of action.
16. Close the meeting in time.

## **IF YOU ARE TO ATTEND A MEETING**

1. Go to the meeting well prepared.
2. (a) Study the agenda carefully, try to find out the items of your interest and the items in which you are capable to make contributions.  
  
(b) Carefully read the information circulated in advance.  
  
(c) If you want to use any written or visual aids to make your contributions effective prepare them in advance.

If you are not an experienced speaker it's advisable to write down points.

3. Study other members who are attending the meeting. Their characteristics, like and dislikes, story and weak points, the way they speak and how they react to different ideas and note their areas of specialization.

4. Speak at the end most appropriate time if you have good ideas. Ideas that you have keen to get accepted, present them early enough so that other members can start thinking along the lines of those ideas.

5. If the discussion is moving along desirable lines, you can wait and present your ideas towards the end of the meeting. This will happen if you are giving an air of finality to the discussion and other members may agree with you and the meeting is closed.

## **DISCUSSION**

Discussion – it's a co-operative, critical exchange of opinions, information and ideas about one general subject. It's guided by a leader for the purpose of seeking appropriate, acceptable answers to a question.

- Can be conducted before an audience or it can be held in a closed session.

- An ideal one involves a force exchange and evaluation of information by open minded participants.

## **PURPOSES OF GROUP DISCUSSION**

1. To solve complex problems. When one or two people are incapable of solving a problem, they often call experts from a variety of areas collective wisdom assists in solving complex problems.

2. To publish existing problems

3. To give individuals experience in becoming leaders and discussants by participating in group deliberations.

4. To collect information from many different people in widely separated

Geographical, occupational or social-economic sections of society.

## **FACTORS INFLUENCING DISCUSSION**

### **1. Amount of research**

The amount of research done by participants before the discussion may affect both the quality of discussions and the quality of the results.

### **2. Underlying motives or secret interests**

May also affect discussion quality and results e.g. people who are not honest and open because they stand to lose something (friends, positions, status etc.) may sway a discussion to protect their secret interests.

### **3. Nonverbal, vocal & verbal messages**

Disgusted expressions, stressed words, or technical terms may suggest attitudes and emotions of the people involved.

### **4. Sensitivity of the participants to each other and to themselves.**

If participants are unaware that others are tense, shy, frustrated or bored they'll probably not be able to draw them into the discussion and benefit from their judgments and opinions.

#### **Other factors may be:**

- Time of day i.e. when the discussion is conducted
- Place where the discussion occurs
- Size of the group discussing
- Time limit for completing a task

### **Types of Discussion Questions**

**There are 3 general types of questions.**

#### **1. Question of fact**

To answer this the discussants try to find which aspects of a particular problem are true, probable or false. These kind of discussions are called "Fact – finding" sessions.

#### **2. Questions of value:**

These questions evaluate different ideas to see which one is best. Discussants compare and contrast the worth or value of one thing with another to make judgments.

#### **3. Questions of policy**

These attempts to discover if something should or should not be done.

Discussion questions should deal with subjects that are: Significant, important and worth discussing.

### **ESTABLISHING A FRAMEWORK FOR AN ORDERLY DISCUSSION.**

It should follow a logical, sequential pattern; the following is the modified plan for discussion.

#### **1. Locate and define the problem**

They need to state the problem clearly so that everyone understand and it may require some terms to be explained from the very beginning, to eliminate confusion once the discussion gets under way.

## **2. Establish criteria for a workplace solution**

After recognition, what the question involves the group must decide on the Standards of criteria that must be met if a solution is to be accepted by the entire group.

## **3. Analyze the problem**

It's a step of exploring the problem, looking for its causes, current status, historical background, probable future and the reason a solution or answer is necessary.

## **4. Suggest and evaluate possible solutions**

The fourth step is to place as many solutions or answers to the problem before the group as possible. Discussants need to be sure each solution meets the standards agreed upon in the second step.

## **5. Evaluate all solutions and select the best one**

In this, they compare and contrast all the alternatives, solutions or answers. The advantages and disadvantages of each one should be weighed in an attempt to discover the one that would best solve the problem.

## **6. Suggest ways for testing or conveying out the solution.**

This step may not be included if the discussion purpose is only to solve problem. However it becomes the last step if the group discusses ways and means of carrying out a solution.

## **METHODS OF EVALUATION**

There are two methods of evaluation, namely:

- i. interaction and participation diagrams
- ii. Discussion critique

## **Types of Discussion**

The type of discussion held depends on such factors as number of participants the subject to be discussed and the time allowed for the discussion.

### **1. Panel Discussion – Involves four – eight members.**

There are no prepared speeches, instead discussions are expected to follow specific lines to find an answer to question. No set pattern for participation.

### **2. Symposium**

This requires individual discussants either to deal with one assigned area of a discussion question or to present their unique viewpoints on the subject.

### **3. Round table discussion**

This doesn't include audience participation although observers may be present. It usually begins with a statement of the problem. This is followed by a series of brief reports or observations by several specialists then discussants spontaneously interact.

### **4. Lecture Discussion**

It includes periods of formal, structured presentations or lectures by the discussion leader. Members of discussion group may be given advance assignments to prepare for the lectures. The leader normally designates specific individuals to respond to certain questions, information or statements. The discussants are allowed to interrupt the leader with questions.

### **5. Progressive Discussion**

It involves several small groups which discuss various, assigned aspects of the same question at the same time. Before the end of discussion period, each leader reports the findings and decisions made by his/her group to the entire session.

### **QUESTIONS**

1. List and explain the key areas of effective communication.
2. Give the functions of a business letter
3. What are the essentials of effective business letter?
4. Identify the various elements of a business letter
5. Mention the various functions of memo
6. How does one achieve brevity in communication?

**UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS**

**COURSE: ALL COURSES**

**LESSON 17: INTERVIEWS**

**OBJECTIVES: At the end of the lesson, the student should understand:**

- The meaning of interviews
- The purpose of interviews
- The interviewing techniques
- The interviewer's preparation
- How to conduct an interview
- How to prepare for an interview
- How to conduct yourself during the interview

## INTERVIEWS

### DEFINITION

Interview means view between. It means two people meeting for the purpose of getting to view each other or knowing each other. The interviewer is interested to know whether or not the candidate can fit in the open position. On the other hand, the interviewees will assess the organization to decide whether or not to join it.

### PURPOSE OF INTERVIEWS

- i. Verifies the information obtained through application form and tests.
- ii. Helps obtain additional information from the applicant otherwise not available.
- iii. Gives the candidate necessary facts and information about the job and the organization.
- iv. Helps establish mutual understanding between the company and the candidate and build the company's image.

### INTERVIEWING TECHNIQUES

They include;

#### 1. Screening

This refers to the preliminary interview which is done when there are many applicants for a given post. The aim of screen interview is to eliminate unqualified applicants and prepare a short list of qualified applicants.

#### 2. Random appearance

This method is used when physical appearance is the essential requirement for a given post, such as for bouncers, Air hostesses, policemen and others.

#### 3. Tests

Written or oral tests can be used to test the intelligence, proficiency and general knowledge of the applicants.

#### 4. Under stress interview

In this method the candidate is provoked to test his poise and how he will acquit himself from difficult situations. The candidate may be asked embarrassing questions or asked to demonstrate how he can carry out a given task such as selling items to panelists.

## **INTERVIEWER'S PREPARATION**

You should;

- ii) Have a thorough knowledge of the company, its profile, operations and employment policies.
- iii) Know the nature and profile of the job to be filled.
- iv) Know the type of personality, character or temperament required for the job.
- v) Send all interview messages on time to candidates.
- vi) Make proper seating arrangements for candidates in the waiting room.
- vii) Make the interview room conducive for the interview that is with no interruptions.
- viii) Supply each member of the committee with a copy of the candidate's bio-data.
- ix) Decide before hand who is going to initiate the interview.

## **HOW TO CONDUCT AN INTERVIEW**

1. Welcome the candidate in a friendly way,

Offer warm smile to the candidate, talk to him in a friendly tone of voice, hold a small talk with him in an area he is familiar.

2. After the candidate has been made comfortable you should start talking to him on the subject you want to know about. You will want to know the candidate's qualifications (ability to do the job), aspiration (willingness to do the job), social effectiveness and emotional balance (relationship with others) character (trustworthiness), physical vigor and energy, spouse's attitude towards the job, financial stability, willingness to travel and willingness to make permanent move.

3. Make notes about the candidate and discuss the notes with other panelists when the candidate has left.

4. Give the candidate time to ask questions

5. If a decision is to be made immediately let the candidate know shortly after the discussion.

6. Thank the candidate for his time and tell him by when he should expect a response from you.

## 3. PREPARING FOR AN INTERVIEW

- a – Make sure you know everything there is to know about yourself, such as academic qualifications, ambitions, hobbies, work experience.
- b – Gather as much information about the company as possible e.g. their operations, services, personnel remunerations.
- c – Carry with you all your certificates to the interview room.
- d – Prepare a list of questions you predict the interviewers may ask.
- e – Prepare appropriate answers for your predicted questions.
- f – Prepare questions that you could like to ask during the interview.
- g – Dress appropriately; example for men a black or navy blue suit and a plain light coloured shirt may be winning colours
- h – Arrive for the interview on time, arrival time is ten – fifteen minutes before the time of the interview

## HOW TO CONDUCT YOURSELF DURING THE INTERVIEW

1. Walk carefully into the interview room, do not wear a scowl or a stupid smile when entering the interview room.
2. Greet the interviewers politely avoid shaking hands unless the interviewers stretch their hands to you.
3. Do not sit down until you have been asked to do so, adopt a natural and upright composed posture when seated.
4. Pay attention to what is being said and do not interrupt the interviewer.
5. When responding give relevant answers only and be audible enough for all the panelists to hear you.
6. Do not boast of your capabilities or qualifications.
7. If there is something you don't know admit it straight away.
8. If you are being interviewed by someone who does not possess as many degrees as yourself do not put on airs. Give the interviewers your co-operation and respect.
9. Be calm throughout the interview do not lose your temper or argue with the panelists these may not work your way.

10. Adopt a positive approach throughout the interview; express your enthusiasm for the job and the company. If you give an impression that you are not interested you may realize that the interviewer is also not interested in hiring you.

11. Avoid shifting in your seat, chewing fingers, smoothing your hair, adjusting the knot of your tie or playing with the pen or paper. All these are signs of nervousness. Nervousness is your worst enemy in interview.

12. When you are asked about your previous employer, be frank but do not criticize your former employer. Mention only positive aspects of your former employer.

13. Ask questions where full information has not been provided by the interviewer.

14. When the interview is over do not forget to thank the interviewer. You can ask tactfully when the results will be made known to you.

## **Guidelines for Effective Interviewing**

There are some guidelines and if observed, can make interview more effective:

1. The interview should have a definite time schedule known to both the interviewers and the interviewee.

2. Interview should be conducted by the competent, trained and experienced interviewers.

3. The interviewers should be supplied with specific set of guidelines for conducting interview.

4. The interviewers should ensure an element of privacy for the interviewee.

5. A resume for all the candidates to be interviewed should be prepared and the same be made available to the interviewers before the interview starts.

6. The interview should not end abruptly but it should come to close tactfully providing satisfaction to the interviewee.

7. The interviewers should show their sensitivity to the interviewee's sentiments and also sympathetic attitude to him/her.

8. The interviewers should also evince emotional maturity and a stable personality during the interview session.

## **TYPICAL INTERVIEW QUESTIONS**

♣ Tell me about yourself

- ♣ Why have you applied for this job?
- ♣ Why have you applied to this company?
- ♣ What evidence can you offer that demonstrates you have the skills we are seeking?
- ♣ Can you give me an example of a problem you have solved?
- ♣ Why did you choose your particular degree?
- ♣ What are your strengths and weaknesses?
- ♣ Where do you see yourself in five years' time?
- ♣ What do you do in your leisure time?

## **SUMMARY**

## **INTERVIEW CHECKLIST**

### **DO**

- Remember that first appearances count – how you dress and act
- Smile, make eye contact and acknowledge all members of an interview panel
- Shake hands in a firm but gentle way, not crushingly strong
- Wait to be asked to sit down
- Make sure you sit correctly and comfortably before starting
- Show interest
- Answer the question asked
- Keep positive at all times

### **DO NOT**

- Be late
- Fidget or look at your watch
- Argue
- Put anything on the interviewer's desk
- Say anything negative
- Appear indifferent
- Appear aggressive or act in a superior way – nobody likes this!

- Show too much interest in money and holidays

## REFERENCE:

- <https://www.yourarticlelibrary.com/hrm/interview-definition-objectives-types-and-guidelines-for-effective-interviewing/35268>
- “Best Answers to the 201 Most Frequently Asked Interview Questions”, Matthew J. DeLuca

## QUESTIONS:

1. Briefly outline the qualities of a good speaker.
2. Define listening and techniques of a good listener
3. What is the purpose of meetings?
4. Differentiate between interviewer and meeting.

## UNIT: COMMUNICATION SKILLS

### COURSE: ALL COURSES

### LESSON 18: PUBLIC RELATIONS AND CUSTOMER CARE

**OBJECTIVES:** At the end of the lesson, the student should understand:

- Understand the definition of terms
- Understand the different types of customers
- Learn the role of public relations and customer in an organization
- Understand customer care and public relations skills needed
- Understand the challenges faced in public relations and customer care

Public-Refers to a group of people with a common interest.

Customer- A person who buys goods or services from a shop or business.

Public Relations - is the deliberate, planned and sustained effort to establish and maintain mutual understanding between on organization and its publics.

## TYPES OF CUSTOMERS

**Loyal Customers-** These types of customers are less in numbers but promote more sales and profit as compared to other customers as these are the ones which are completely satisfied. These customers revisit the organization over times hence it is crucial to interact and keep in touch with them on a regular basis and invest much time and effort with them. Loyal customers want individual attention and that demands polite and respectful responses from supplier.

**Discount Customers-** Discount customers are also frequent visitors but they are only a part of business when offered with discounts on regular products and brands or they buy only low cost products. More is the discount the more they tend towards buying. These customers are mostly related to small industries or the industries that focus on low or marginal investments on products. Focus on these types of customers is also important as they also promote distinguished part of profit into business.

**Impulsive Customers-** These customers are difficult to convince as they want to do the business in urge or caprice. They don't have any specific item into their product list but urge to buy what they find good and productive at that point of time. Handling these customers is a challenge as they are not particularly looking for a product and want the supplier to display all the useful products they have in their tally in front of them so that they can buy what they like from that display. If impulsive customers are treated accordingly then there is high probability that these customers could be a responsible for high percentage of selling.

**Need Based Customers-** These customers are product specific and only tend to buy items only to which they are habitual or have a specific need for them. These are frequent customers but do not become a part of buying most of the times so it is difficult to satisfy them. These customers should be handled positively by showing them ways and reasons to switch to other similar products and brands and initiating them to buy these. These customers could possibly be lost if not tackled efficiently with positive interaction.

**Wandering Customers-** These are the least profitable customers as sometimes they themselves are not sure what to buy. These customers are normally new in industry and most of the times visit suppliers only for confirming their needs on products. They investigate features of most prominent products in the market but do not buy any of those or show least interest in buying. To grab such customers they should be properly informed about the various positive features of the products so that they develop a sense of interest.

## CONCLUSION

An organization should always focus on loyal customers and should expand or multiply the product range to leverage impulsive customers. For other types of customers strategies should be renovated and enhanced for turning out these customers to satisfy their needs and modify these types of customers to let them fall under loyal and impulsive category.

**(Types of customers)**

**REFERENCE:**

<https://www.managementstudyguide.com/types-of-customers.htm>

## ROLE OF PUBLIC RELATIONS AND CUSTOMER IN AN ORGANIZATION

- I. **Crisis Management** – Establishing methods and policies to be used when an organization's operations become involved in an emergency affecting the public. This includes policies and procedures for the distribution of information to employees, media, government and other key publics.
- II. **Issues Management** – This involves identifying problems, issues and trends relevant to an organization and then developing and executing a program to deal with them. Included is the study of public policy matters of concern to an organization.
- III. **Relationship Management** – This involves the role of public relations in identifying key publics and establishing strategies for building and maintaining mutually beneficial relationships with those publics.
- IV. **Resource Management** – PR's management of human and financial resources revolves around setting objectives, planning, budgeting, recruiting and hiring PR staff and administering those resources.
- V. **Strategic Management** – Acting as a counselor, the PR practitioner serves on the management team helping the organization develop sound policies that are in the best interests of the public as well as the organization. The PR practitioner integrates an understanding of the concerns and attitudes of key publics into the organization's managerial decision-making process.
- VI. **Reputation or image management** – The planning and implementing of policies, procedures and strategies that demonstrate the commitment of the organization to public and social responsibility, ethical behaviour, corporate identity and reputation with key publics.
- VII. Maintaining a positive, empathetic and professional attitude toward customers at all times.
- VIII. Responding promptly to customer inquiries.
- IX. Communicating with customers through various channels.
- X. Acknowledging and resolving customer complaints.
- XI. Knowing our products inside and out so that you can answer questions.
- XII. Processing orders, forms, applications, and requests.
- XIII. Keeping records of customer interactions, transactions, comments and complaints.
- XIV. Communicating and coordinating with colleagues as necessary.
- XV. Providing feedback on the efficiency of the customer service process.
- XVI. Managing a team of junior customer service representatives.
- XVII. Ensure customer satisfaction and provide professional customer support.

## **CUSTOMER CARE AND PUBLIC RELATIONS SKILLS**

### **I. Honesty**

In public relations, your reputation is key. Being upfront, honest and sticking to your core values in your working life will not only help you sleep better at night but enhance your networks and the quality of your work. Alternative facts, spin and mistruths will diminish your hard work when representing a client and their brand. To make your mark in the PR world, stick to the truth.

### **2. Knowledge and research**

The ability to undertake research and build your knowledge of a client's product or service is key. Keeping up to date on the latest market trends, competition, technology, and customer desires will assist you in having a successful career in PR. Further, conducting background research ensures your ability to meet the needs of your clients without a sweat, and speak with journalists and analysts about your subject matter with confidence and ease. For example, some PR firms specialize in niche tech areas, so promoting yourself as an individual who has grasped the workings of technology and the fast-paced nature of the tech industry will make you a preferred contact over those who rely solely on other skills.

### **3. Relationship-building skills**

More than a soft skill, the ability to build your professional network is a crucial skill for success in PR. Your ability to build relationships in expressing your confidence and charisma will complement oral and written communication skills, making you a great PR representative.

### **4. Multi-tasking in a high pressure work environment**

In the high pressure environment of PR, the ability to work on multiple projects at any one time will be part of your everyday. This means handling multiple clients with varying needs and differing deadlines. Professionals who thrive and enjoy working in such a fast-paced environment will love the energy of PR.

### **5. Attention to detail**

Accuracy in your work is essential for a successful and long career in PR. The ability of a PR professional to tell their clients' stories through the fast-paced and ever-evolving media demands accuracy and attention to detail. When constantly reviewing and editing written content for clients, it is crucial to deliver a flawless edit, as even the smallest of mistakes could be the difference between a campaign's success or failure.

## **6. Adapts to change**

The media landscape is constantly changing. People are consuming media through apps and social media more than ever, where click bait as a style of reporting is normal. As a PR expert, you must be flexible and adapt to these changes.

## **7. Strategic thinking**

PR managers must have the ability to think on their feet. It's now very rare to meet journalists and media buyers face-to-face, so quick strategic thinking will help you get across a client's brand, make a pitch, run events and successfully execute campaigns. Excellent strategic thinking comes from a place of passion, vision, and knowing your subject matter like the back of your hand.

## **8. Social media savvy**

The rise of social media in recent years has been one of the greatest catalysts for change in the PR and media industry. Not only has Twitter and Facebook changed the way media is consumed, it has turned content preparation on its head. PR professionals now create content around social media as the key delivery piece for a client's campaign. A great feature behind social media's power is the ability to measure a campaign's reach and overall effectiveness when using social channels. Even using LinkedIn to communicate with clients, editors and media buyers is now more common than ever before. Being social media savvy will take you places in the industry.

## **9. Write well**

Having polished writing skills is extremely important for a public relations professional. If you can't organise your thoughts on a page, you will find it very difficult to communicate with clients and colleagues. The more styles you can write in, the better!

## **10. Presentation skills**

Great oral presentation and communication skills are a must. Gaining presentation practice is key, as you're going to passionately outline and explain your creative ideas to your clients, media buyers, and journalists who expect a professional and insightful delivery of information.

## **REFERENCE:**

<https://www.ici.net.au/blog/11-skills-you-need-for-a-career-in-public-relations-and-media/>

## **CHALLENGES FACED BY PUBLIC RELATIONS AND CUSTOMER CARE**

### **1. Financial Constraint**

There is no doubt that organizations are cutting budgets, thereby leading to poor financing of the public relations department. Financial belt-tightening has stemmed the flow of public relations' budgets. Companies are reluctant to spend the little revenue they have on improving their media profile. Ironically, now is the time for them to raise their profile and gain new custom.

## **2. Poor Man-Power Situation**

It is a known fact that most practitioners of public relations have background disciplines in other field of studies. Some are practicing journalists, marketers, advertisers, graphic artists, psychologists and so on; the truth is, they lack comprehensive understanding of what it takes to be a full practitioners in Public relations. Those disciplines are relevant to gaining an expertise in public relations, but they need to be merged with core public relations courses to achieve the birthing of a fully-fledged public relations expertise.

## **3. Having to serve multiple customers at the same time**

If you are working in customer service, you need to be prepared to deal with several customers at a time on daily basis.

## **4. Facing an irate customer**

Dealing with angry customers is part of the deal you are entering a customer service job. There is no escaping it.

There is a long list of advice spoken on this subject. And the reason is that it's really not easy. If I am to take a single **line to give my own advice, it is "Remain calm yourself"**.

## **5. Being time-pressed to give a response when you don't have one**

There are situations when a customer is rushing you to give them a response, but you don't actually know what to say, because either you don't understand how to solve their problem or you don't have enough information.

In such situations, I recommend to hold your ground and insist on taking your time to investigate the issue. Not buying into the rush will help you to give a better quality customer service. You can say, for example, "I will need some time to research the issue and do some testing. Would it be ok if I emailed you with the results later today?" Or you could say, "I will need to check this up with our administrator/manager. Could you please leave me your email and I will get back to you shortly."

## **6. Crisis management**

A crisis is inevitable. A crisis is unexpected event that happens and threatens to ruin the reputation of the organization. Your organization can get hit by a natural disaster e.g. fire, theft

etc. , some negative news may spiral out of control or the company has some financial challenges that spark media coverage.

Moments of crisis can be incredibly stressful and a lot is usually asked of the PR and communications teams during this times.

To make sure you can get through a crisis as best as you can, it is vital to prepare for it.

Communication is key during a crisis – knowing where and how to communicate is essential to your strategy. Make sure you have a protocol in place that will guide you through the crisis and reflect afterward to improve your current protocol.

## **Time management**

Time management is a critical component of every job, the PR professional is no exception.

With tight deadlines, many interests at stake, and news getting out 24/7, PR professionals have a lot to deal with.

To stay on top of all the tasks you need to take care of, make sure you manage your time by creating overviews and priorities. Schedule your tasks in a calendar, estimate how long tasks will take and plan them in accordingly.

**QUESTION: 1.Distinguish between public relations and customer care.(4mks)**

**3. Highlight the challenges faced by public relations and customer care in an organization.**

## **COMMUNICATION PAST PAPER QUESTIONS**

1. Explain two essentials of a valid meeting.(4mks)
2. Distinguish between interpersonal communication and intrapersonal communication.(4mks)
3. Distinguish between public relations and customer care.(4mks)
4. Outline two objectives that the management of an organization may seek to achieve through downward communication.(2mks)
5. The management of Kazi works Limited has noted reduced motivation levels among the production staff. As a Foreman, you have been requested to investigate the matter and write a report. Assuming that you have completed the investigations, write the report.(10mks)
6. The position of supervisors has fallen in Pema Engineering Limited. Draft an advertisement for this position which is to be placed in one of the local dailies.(6mks)

7. Baraka enterprise has commissioned a consultancy firm to interview candidates for the position of foreman. Outline six guidelines that the consultant should follow when preparing for the interview.(6mks)
8. Outline three functions of communication .(3mks)
9. List three types of noise that may hinder an individual from communicating effectively.
10. List four reasons why an individual should observe etiquette when communication with an audience. (4mks)
11. State three reasons why reports should be edited before dissemination.(3mks)
12. Outline four ways in which an individual may prepare for a live interview.(4mks)
13. State three channels of communication used by public relations officers to pass information to internal publics.(3mks)
14. List three functions of the minutes of a meeting.(3mks)
15. Write an essay of about 250 words on:  
    “The impact of climate change on the Kenyan economy”. (10mks)
16. You work as the secretary of Inua Jamii Organization. The organizations Executive Committee held a meeting recently in which the following agenda items, among other were discussed:
  - a) Security risks facing members;
  - b) Collaboration with sister associations in other countries;
  - c) Income generating activities.

Write minutes of the meeting. (16 mks)

17. Explain four characteristics of good recommendation in a report.(8mks)